

AN AFRICAN GOLD NOVEL
THE SPIRITUAL FOURTH

AFRIKA 2100

They were never here for the gold.

ANDRIES J. GREYLING

ARJUNA BADGER PRESS

AFRIKA 2100

An African Gold novel • The spiritual fourth

Andries J. Greyling

AFRIKA 2100

Copyright © 2026 Andries J. Greyling. All rights reserved.

This is a work of fiction. Names, characters, places, and incidents are the product of the author's imagination or are used fictitiously. Any resemblance to actual persons, living or dead, events, or locales is coincidental. Real places, historical traditions, and scientific references are used in a fictional context.

Published by the House of Greyling.

ISBN: --_--_ (assigned at print)

Per Ardua ad Magnum.

A Note to the Reader

This is a work of fiction, and it is the fourth time I have walked this ground.

RESONANCE, *REVELATION*, and *RELIC* told the story of a machine beneath Africa and the people who had to decide what to do about it. This book is not their sequel so much as their consequence: it asks what the world looks like seventy years after a handful of engineers chose understanding over power — and what happens when the question they answered gets asked again, larger, by someone standing politely on the tarmac.

Some of this book's furniture is real. The physics of a Carrington-class solar flare is real, and the vulnerability of long high-latitude power grids to geomagnetically induced currents is real — as is the relative shelter of southern latitudes. The Bushveld Complex really does hold most of the world's platinum. The Witwatersrand's gold really is older than almost anything human hands have touched. The Amish and Old Order communities really do hold, intact and living, the complete craft of a life that does not need the grid — and the imagined partnership in these pages is written in admiration of that competence, not as costume. Where the book touches Plain faith and practice, it does so with respect; the errors that remain are mine.

The rest — the visitors, the instrument, the Fold, the port at eGoli, and the engineer-saint whose copyleft stack carries this imagined century — is fiction, built the way this house builds: every miracle a machine, every faith honoured as meaning, both sides of every contested thing given their best argument.

We are, all of us, more alike than we are different.

— Andries J. Greyling

Dedication

For the ones who keep things working when nobody is watching and nothing is certain — the linesmen, the surveyors, the quartermasters, the grandmothers.

The lights came back because of you.

The note carries.

“They came for the gold. It was never about the gold.”

— attributed to a tuning-guild manual, author unrecorded

Chapter 1 — The Tolerances

eGoli Spaceport, Gauteng · six weeks to Renewal

Read the tolerance before you read the intent. The maker is in the margin.

— Tuning Guild founding manual, vol. I, epigraph. Author unrecorded.

The hull came down the last hundred metres the way everything about the visitors moved: as if hurry were a concept it had examined and declined.

Naledi Mokoena watched it on the board, not through the glass. Juniors watched through the glass. The glass showed you a shape the size of a grain silo lowering itself out of a highveld morning with no sound except the wind it displaced, and the shape was so far outside what eyes were built for that eyes just gave up and reported *large*. The board told the truth. The board showed eleven hundred tonnes of something that read to radar like a question mark, riding down a column of nothing anyone could name, at nine centimetres per second, dead on the centreline of Berth Six.

“Coupling in forty,” said Mothusi, on her left. “Rails are singing.”

“They’re not singing, they’re drifting,” Naledi said. “Bring your reference up before it couples, or you’ll be tuning the port to the ship instead of the ship to the port.”

“Yebo, yes.” He brought it up. The drift on his channel flattened out.

The berth rails were gold. Not plated — worked. Four hundred metres of conductor refined and formed to tolerances the old bullion trade never dreamed of, laid into the apron like the strings of an instrument

the size of a city block, because that was what they were. When a hull that size sat down, it did not land; it *coupled* — its own resonance let down gently into the port's, matched note against note by the people in this room until the two systems agreed to hold one standing wave between them. The guild called the room the console line. The rest of the port called it the choir, and the guild had stopped fighting the name around the time Naledi was born.

She had been on the line six years. Her grandmother had surveyed the ground it stood on before the first berth was poured, back when it was still the old mine belt — headgear and slimes dams and a century's holes in the earth — and there was a brass plaque with her survey team's names on it by the lifts, which Naledi passed every morning and touched, some mornings, when the shift was going to be long.

This shift was going to be long. Six weeks out from the Great Renewal, the schedule had thickened until the berths never cooled: consignments outbound, delegations inbound, and everything at eGoli moving with the particular tension of a household before a wedding nobody was completely sure about.

"Coupling," Mothusi said.

The hull sat down onto its column of nothing and the board lit from apron to gallery as the standing wave took. Naledi read it left to right, the way you read anything: power first — the platcap banks under the apron taking the coupling surge, thirty seconds of load that would have browned out the Johannesburg of her great-grandmother's day, sunk into platinum-alloy cells and already bleeding back out to the port grid. Structure next — the piezo struts in the berth frame drinking the vibration nobody wanted and turning it into the lights over her console, which was the oldest joke in the guild: *the visitors pay for their own tea*. Then the wave itself, the long braid of it, human port and visitor hull holding one note together, and every harmonic in its lane.

Almost every harmonic in its lane.

"Berth Six is green," Mothusi announced, to the room's general grunt. "Choir's done. Freight can have it."

"Freight can have it," Naledi agreed, and did not move.

Because the consignment calibration was still running on her second screen, and the consignment calibration was doing the thing again.

Outbound consignments were the other half of the guild's work, the half that never made the newsfeeds: gold, worked gold, refined past nine-nines purity and formed in the port's own refinery row into the geometries the manifests specified, verified by the guild before loading because a mistuned component was a rejected component, and a rejected component was a diplomatic month nobody wanted. The verification was routine. It was the most routine thing in the port. You keyed the consignment's resonance profile against the manifest's declared purpose — *maintenance, network, repair schedule 9* was what the manifests had said, with minor variations, for twenty-nine years — and the profile matched, and you signed, and eleven hundred tonnes of patience carried it away to wherever the network's failing pieces were.

The profile on her screen matched. That was the thing. It matched at every declared line, sat sweetly inside every tolerance the manifest named. If she signed, no gate would refuse her, and no auditor would blink.

But the manifest's tolerances were wide, the way a doorway is wide, and inside that doorway the actual signature stood off-centre — and it stood off-centre the way it had stood off-centre on the last consignment she'd verified, and the one before that, and, she was increasingly sure, though she'd need the archive to prove it, on consignments going back a lot further than her sign-off history.

Repair looked a certain way. She had spent six years learning exactly what it looked like. When you patched a resonant system you saw broadband compensation — energy spread to shore up whatever was sagging, the acoustic equivalent of a splint. What she was looking at was narrow. Narrow, coherent, repeatable across consignments, and pointed. Energy disciplined toward a single spectral line, the way you disciplined a system when you were not mending it but *tuning* it — bringing something, somewhere, to a pitch.

The pitch was always the same pitch.

She sat with it for a minute, which on the console line was a long time. Around her the room ran its ordinary business: the choir chirping between channels, freight bickering with scheduling, somebody's tea

going cold, the enormous quiet presence at Berth Six ticking as its skin equalised, if skin was even the word. Through the west glass, far across the apron, the rotor-anomaly testbed was running one of its endless charge cycles, a crystalline flywheel the size of a small room hanging a handspan off its cradle in a way that four hundred years of physics could describe to nine decimal places and not explain. She had grown up with all of it. The visitors, the port, the anomaly, the folded Sundays, the whole patient furniture of the century — it was just the world. Her world, in the specific way it was nobody else's: third generation on this ground, guild since twenty-two, her name on a console the way her grandmother's was on a plaque.

Which was, she would think later, exactly why she couldn't leave it alone. You could lie to a stranger. The port was not a stranger.

She opened a discrepancy log.

The form was old, older than the port — inherited from mine practice through the guild's founding generation, and it had the founding generation's fingerprints all over it: field after field demanding the *cue*. Not what you felt. What you measured, where, with what, at what confidence, referenced to which baseline. Somewhere in the guild's manuals — she'd noticed it as a cadet and it still snagged her, some shifts — there was a voice underneath the procedure, dry and exact and never named, an engineer from before the Flare who had apparently believed you could teach pattern-reading the way you taught arc welding, and had nearly been right. *Read the tolerance before you read the intent*, the epigraph said. *The maker is in the margin*.

The maker was in the margin. Something was.

She keyed it in plainly, the way the form wanted. *Consignment 100-417, outbound verification. Signature conforms to manifest MNT/NW/RS-9 within declared tolerances. Sustained coherent offset from declared repair profile: +2.94 sigma, spectral line 441-something* — she typed the full designation — *consistent with offsets logged informally on 100-409 and 100-412. Assessment: profile indicates disciplined tuning toward a common reference, not broadband compensation. Repair manifest may be incomplete as a description of use. Recommend: archive correlation against waking-note baseline, 2064, custodial series.*

Her cursor sat on the last line for a while.

The 2064 logs were sealed. Everyone knew the 2064 logs were sealed, the way everyone knew the Stewards had halted two consignments in twenty-nine years and never said why, the way everyone knew which questions were freight and which were not. A verification tech asking to norm her curve against the custodial series was not doing anything wrong. She was just doing something that had, as far as Naledi knew, never once been done.

Down on the apron, the freight gantries were already walking their loads toward Berth Six, an e-grav frame under the big platcap bank shedding a third of the weight in ninety-second sips so the rails wouldn't groan. The morning was bright and enormous. Somewhere north of the refinery row a bird was giving the port its opinion, which was the same opinion birds had given the mine before it and the veld before that.

It's not wrong, she thought. *It's undeclared*. And the whole shape of her life afterward would hang on the difference, though all she knew at the time was that her grandmother had gone down into the old workings for three years for the Accord survey and come up with maps everyone trusted and a silence nobody questioned, and that Naledi had inherited the trust and the silence both, and had room left over for exactly one of them.

She signed the verification, because the verification was true.

Then she filed the discrepancy log, timestamped, onto the guild record, where things could be closed but never uncreated — and went back to work, because the board was filling again, and at eGoli the sky was always coming down slowly toward somebody.

It was the ninth of September, 2100, six weeks to the Renewal, and the first domino went over making no sound at all.

Chapter 2 — The Blessing of the Load

Lancaster Compact zone, Pennsylvania · six weeks to Renewal

The barn had been a church for thirty-six years, which was longer than it had ever been a barn.

Ruth Stoltzfus sat in the fourth row on the visitors' side, in uniform, with her cover on her knee, and let the singing come up around her like water finding its level. The hymn was High German, four hundred years old, unaccompanied, led from the middle of the congregation by whoever the note found first — and when it ended, the reader stood up with the folded lectionary and gave out the day's passages in English, because the Fold's book belonged to everybody and Deutsch was for the hymns.

"From the Psalms," the reader said. He was a Beiler, one of the young ones, with hay dust still on his shoulders from the morning feed. "Then from the Dhammapada. Then from the sayings of the Nguni, collected. One inheritance."

One inheritance, the congregation answered, and the reading began.

Ruth had been six years old when the sky burned. What she remembered was not fear. She had been asleep, and then her mother was carrying her into the yard in a quilt, and the whole bowl of the night was green and rose and moving, aurora down over Pennsylvania like the Lord had hung washing across every star at once, and her father had said, very quietly, to no one, "*Now we find out.*" She was too small to know what he meant. She knew now. The neighbours' farms — the English farms, as her people had still said then — had gone

dark and stayed dark, and the milk had died in the tanks, and the cars had worked but the fuel pumps hadn't, and the phones in everyone's pockets had become mirrors, and within a month the roads were full of people walking out of the cities carrying the wrong things.

Her community's farms had not gone dark, because they had never been lit. That was the whole of it. Thirty-six years of theology and policy and the Fold's careful liturgies had grown up over that fact like sod over a foundation, but the fact stayed simple: when the grid died, her people did not notice for three days, and when they did notice, it was because of the walkers on the roads.

And then the Army had come. She remembered that too: the convoy crawling up the pike in June of sixty-five, and the colonel who got down from the lead truck and took off his sunglasses and stood in her family's lane with his hands empty, and asked — asked — for the bishop.

The reading ended. The congregation folded down onto the benches for the silence, and Ruth folded with them, and in the silence, as always, did her accounting. It was the one piece of the practice she had carried whole through twenty-three years of the Army: the ledger of kindnesses, kept nightly, an honest count of what you had put into the world that day and what you had taken out. The Fold said the count was the prayer. Her grandmother, who had died holding the old faith entire and unfolded, had said the same thing about weeding.

Don't be a cunt. Be kind.

It was on the coin in her breast pocket, the ledger-coin the width of her thumb, G's face on one side and the terminal ethic on the other, and the first time her grandmother had seen the words — Ruth had been fourteen, the coins new, the Fold newer — the old woman had read them through her spectacles, twice, and handed it back and said, in Deutsch, "Coarse. True. So was Luther." It remained the only theological ruling Ruth had ever needed on the matter.

After the silence came the announcements, and after the announcements, the thing the whole district had turned out for. They went into the June morning together, the congregation and the visitors' side both, out past the horse lines to the yard, where the load stood waiting.

Eight wagons. Army gun-carriages, technically, drawn up in a double column with their draft teams dozing in the traces — Percherons on the lead pairs, and behind each wagon its Army escort standing easy in dress uniform, and on each wagon bed, under canvas and cordage and customs seals, a low dense stack of boxes that did not look like anything at all. Gold never did. Two hundred and forty tonnes of it, refined in Compact refineries from Compact claims and old Treasury stock, worked — this was the part that still bent her mind, quietly, every time — to resonance geometries specified by a counterparty from another star, verified by liaison metrologists, and bound for eGoli, where Ruth would deliver it into the hands of the Renewal.

The bishop blessed the load. That was the custom, Compact-made, thirty years old, and like everything the Compact made it was a negotiation nobody had written down: the bishop prayed in Deutsch and English over the wagons the way the old faith prayed over a barn-raising, and the Army stood covered and silent and let him, and the Fold's reader gave the two sentences at the end, and every party present heard what it needed to hear. Provision for a journey. Sanctification of a tribute. Good order before a movement. One inheritance.

"Captain Stoltzfus." Major-General Okafor found her at the head of the column while the families were saying their goodbyes to the escort troopers, half of whom were district boys. The general had come down from Harrisburg for the send-off, which told Ruth most of what she needed to know about how far up the anxiety went. "Walk with me a minute."

They walked the column. The general touched a wheel rim, a canvas edge, the flank of a Percheron, with the air of a man verifying that the world was still material.

"Your orders are in the packet," he said. "Deliver the consignment. Attend the Renewal as consignment officer. Render assistance to the delegation as required. All of which you could do asleep, which is not why you were picked." He stopped walking. "You were picked because the Amish trust you and the Army trusts you and there aren't nine people on this continent who can say both."

"Eight of them smarter than me, sir."

"Undoubtedly. Here's the question nobody will put in writing, Captain, and nobody will thank you for answering, and the President's office

wants answered anyway.” He looked down the column, at the wagons, at the boxes that did not look like anything. “When we hand that over — what is it? Is it trade? Is it tribute? Is it an offering plate?” He said the last one carefully, like a man handling someone else’s scripture. “Because from where the North sits, we are shipping the price of a rebuilt hemisphere to the one country that didn’t burn, to give to someone we can’t refuse, for reasons they won’t state, and every soul from here to the Dakotas who prays over that load on a Sunday deserves better than *we’re not sure*.”

Ruth was quiet for a moment. Down the column, Sergeant Amos Beiler — first cousin to the morning’s reader, Plain-raised and never left, the only man she’d ever met who could make a supply manifest sound like a psalm — was showing a knot of children how the wagon brakes worked, gravely, one small hand at a time on the lever.

“Sir,” she said, “my grandmother had a rule for gifts. She said you don’t know what a thing is when you give it. You know when you see what it makes of the people who took it.”

“That’s a long answer.”

“It’s a six-week road, sir. I’ll have a shorter one by eGoli.”

Okafor almost smiled. “That’s why you were picked.” He put his sunglasses on, which meant the conversation was ending and the convoy was starting, and then he paused, and said the other thing, the thing she would carry down the whole Atlantic like a stone in a boot: “Twenty-nine years, Captain, they’ve never once told us what the gold is *for*. Repair, the manifests say. Repair of what? We’re praying on Sundays and paying on Mondays and we have never seen the invoice. If anyone down there ever reads it —” he looked at her over the glasses, and he was not smiling at all — “I’d take it kindly if an American was in the room.”

“Yes, sir.”

“Move your column, Captain.”

The whips never touched the teams; Compact drivers didn’t carry them. Amos swung up beside her on the lead wagon with the movement order in his fist, cleared his throat, and gave out the departure the way he gave out everything.

“Eight wagons, two hundred forty ton, six weeks, one question,” he said. “Sell gut. Let’s go find out.”

The column rolled south into the green morning, through the district her people had farmed without electricity for three hundred years and would farm for three hundred more, past the transformer graveyard at the county line that the Compact kept mowed like a war cemetery, which it was. Ruth put her hand once against her breast pocket, coin and Bible both, the folded and the unfolded, and settled in for the road.

Behind them the barn that was a church stood open to the morning, and the last of the congregation watched the wagons out of sight, the way her people had watched wagons out of sight in Switzerland, in the Palatinate, in Ohio and Indiana and here, for four hundred years: with a prayer, and without waving, and with every intention of being exactly where they stood when the wagons came back.

Chapter 3 — Closed as Filed

eGoli Spaceport · five and a half weeks to Renewal

The response came back in four days, which was fast for the guild record system, and it came back two words long, which was fast for anybody.

Closed as filed.

No reviewer comments. No correlation run. No answer at all to the recommendation line, which had been the entire point of the log — just the status flag flipped from OPEN to CLOSED, a review level two grades above anything a consignment discrepancy usually earned, and a signature block so thoroughly abbreviated it might as well have been a thumbprint in wax.

Naledi read it standing at her console at the start of the morning shift, and then read it again, and the second reading did what second readings do: it stopped being information about the log and started being information about the people who had closed it.

A junior reviewer dismisses you with a paragraph, because a junior reviewer has to show their work. Two grades up, they do not have to show their work. Two grades up, at Renewal season, somebody had looked at a verification tech's three-sigma curve and the words *waking-note baseline, 2064, custodial series*, and reached not for a red pen but for a lid.

"You've got your reading face on," said Mothusi, sliding into the next seat with his tea. "Whose telemetry died?"

“Nobody’s,” she said, and closed the screen, and ran her shift.

She ran it well, which was the part nobody tells you about a splinter in the mind: the work doesn’t get worse. The work gets *better*, because the work is the one place the splinter goes quiet. She coupled a delegation transport at Berth Two and a heavy freighter at Nine, verified two outbound consignments — both of them off-centre in the doorway, both of them at the same pitch, and she logged nothing, this time, and noticed exactly what it cost her to log nothing — and at the end of the shift Baba Sipho Dlamini was standing behind her chair with his hands in the pockets of the grey guild coat he’d worn since before she was a cadet.

“Walk with me, my child,” he said.

Everyone in the guild was Baba Sipho’s child; that was just the grammar of him. He had tuned the first berth ever poured, had shaken the hands of three presidents and declined a fourth, and had a way of walking the refinery row at shift-change so that every young tuner got looked at, once, properly, the way a farmer looks at weather. He had recruited Naledi out of a harvester-engineering apprenticeship at twenty-two on the strength of a maintenance log she’d written about a piezo strut array — she had flagged that one strut’s output was *too clean*, and traced it to a mounting fault that was quietly bypassing its load sensor — and he’d told her, in the interview, that the guild had exactly one entrance requirement, and she had already passed it: *you noticed that right can be a symptom*.

They walked the row. Below the catwalk, the evening pour was going into the moulds, gold running thin and blinding into geometries that had no name in any human trade, and the heat came up in slow breaths.

“I closed your log,” Baba Sipho said.

She had not expected the directness, and then she had, because it was him. “The signature block said review level six.”

“The signature block said what I asked it to say. It was my hand.” He stopped, folded his arms on the rail, and watched the pour. “Your curve is good, Naledi. Your curve is the best piece of verification work I have seen this year, and I have told no one that, and I am telling you the way a man tells you where the fence is electrified.”

The gold ran. “Do you know what season it is?”

“Renewal season.”

“Renewal season. Forty governments and their press corps are landing on my apron. In six weeks the species signs the only treaty it has ever signed that matters, or it doesn’t. And into that season, a tuner I trained — third generation on this ground, a name everyone in this port knows because it is riveted to the lift-shaft wall — asks the record system to unseal the *custodial series*.” He said it without heat, which was worse. “There are three newsfeeds that would pay a year of your salary for that log. Not because they understand the curve. Because of what the headline does. *Guild questions what the gold is for*. Six weeks out. You may be right, my child. That is the thing about this season: being right is not the only load on the wire.”

“Then norm the curve quietly,” Naledi said. “You have custodial liaison. You could request the 2064 baseline through the Stewards without it ever touching the public record. If I’m wrong, the curve dies in a locked room and no headline ever exists. If I’m right—”

“If you are right,” Baba Sipho said, “it is not a curve, it is a question about twenty-nine years of consignments, and questions about twenty-nine years of consignments are not asked by verification techs, they are asked by commissioners, at treaty tables, in language that has been through forty lawyers.” He turned and looked at her, and his face was the face from the interview, old and kind and utterly without softness. “After the Renewal, I will requisition the baseline myself. You have my word, and my word in front of you, which is more than my word. Six weeks, Naledi. Give the species its signature. Then we will go and read your margin together.”

It was, she understood as she said good night to him, a completely reasonable position. That was what she chewed on, riding the late transit home over the old mine belt with the port lights wheeling away behind her: everyone in this was going to be reasonable. Nobody was going to twirl a moustache. They were going to be kind, and correct, and they were going to be her own people, and the door was going to close with a sound like *after the Renewal*.

And she had signed two verifications today with the curve sitting in them like a splinter, and the consignments were gone, up, out, wherever *out* was, doing whatever the manifest didn’t say. The Renewal

wasn't a deadline for asking the question. The Renewal was the question, being answered without asking it, at volume, forever.

Her flat was in Florida — the old West Rand Florida, lake and mine dumps, twenty minutes from the apron — and she didn't go home to it. She rode two stops further to the guild archive annex, badged in at ten at night, which her access class permitted, and sat down at a terminal in the empty reading room, and did the thing you do when the front door is closed: she measured the house.

The sealed series had a catalogue entry. Sealed things always did; that was what sealing meant — the record of a record, the shape of a hole. *Custodial series, 2064.001-2064.988, deep telemetry, waking event and stabilisation. Access: Steward Council key + Port Authority countersign. Deposited 2073, at the Accord. Twelve hundred hours of instrument data. And a deposit note, one line, in the dry administrative English of the founding generation, which stopped her breathing for a second:*

Deposited per survey handover, D. Mokoena attending.

Her grandmother had carried these logs in. Her grandmother, who had surveyed the deep galleries for three years and come home and never once, in twenty-six years of Sunday lunches, of Naledi's cadet stories, of the guild plaque with her name on it — never once said the word *custodial*, or *waking*, or *2064-anything*, to the granddaughter she taught to read contour maps at the kitchen table.

What did you attend, Gogo?

The reading room hummed. Somewhere below it, the archive's plat-caps took their trickle of the port's night load, and the mesh carried its billion small messages, and the instrument — four kilometres down and continent-wide, awake for thirty-six years, older than the species' name for itself — idled at whatever pitch it idled at, undeclared.

Naledi opened a new request form. Not the discrepancy log this time. The other one, the one with the treaty crest on it, that any citizen of an Accord state could file and almost none ever had: *Application for custodial disclosure — grounds must be stated.*

Grounds. She typed the truth, because the form was going onto the ledger where things could be denied but never uncreated, and the

truth was the only load-bearing thing she owned.

Applicant is a guild verification engineer. Applicant has documented a sustained, coherent, repeating offset in outbound consignment resonance profiles, consistent with disciplined tuning toward a common reference not described in the repair manifests. The sealed custodial series contains the only baseline against which this offset can be normed. Applicant's professional assessment: the port is verifying that the gold matches the manifest, without being able to verify that the manifest matches the use. Twenty-nine years of good faith deserve twenty-nine years of good measurement.

She read it twice. It sounded like her grandmother's survey books: no adjectives, all bearings.

At seven minutes past midnight, five and a half weeks before the Great Renewal, Naledi Mokoena put her name to it and filed it onto the public ledger — the one place in the world her guild-master's kindness couldn't close — and rode home over the dark mine belt with her heart going like a coupling surge, and slept, to her own surprise, like a woman who had put a heavy thing down.

By morning the application had four hundred reads. By the following evening, it had a newsfeed headline, a formal acknowledgement from the Steward Council with no date attached, and a meeting request, courteous as a blade being laid flat on a table, from the office of the Accord Commissioner for the Republic of South Africa: *Dr. S. Marais presents his compliments to Engineer Mokoena, and would value an hour of her time.*

Chapter 4 — The Burned Interior

Consolidated Rail, Pennsylvania to Georgia · five weeks to Renewal

The wagons went as far as Columbia, where the river met the rail, and there the gold changed its shoes.

Ruth supervised the transload herself, box by box, wagon bed to rail flat, every seal photographed and hashed to the ledger before and after, while the Percheron teams stood in the June shade being admired by railway men. The Consolidated line would carry the consignment south to the sea. The teams would walk home. There was a small ceremony to it, Compact-style, unwritten: each driver went down his team with his hands and his few words, and then the empty wagons rolled north and the train rolled south, and Amos Beiler stood on the flatcar watching the horses out of sight with an expression Ruth knew better than to speak into.

“Well,” he said at last, as the river bent away. “Now it’s freight.”

The Consolidated main line ran the spine of the old East, and riding it was riding a thirty-six-year argument between what the country had been and what it had decided to become. The train itself was the decision at its plainest: platcap-electric, quiet as weather, drawing its current at each division point from solar farms that had been soy fields, storing it in cells that had been — if you went back far enough, through the licensing and the treaties and one particular Accord technique — a suit joint in a South African mine. Every axle rode on piezo trucks. Amos, who read rolling stock the way his cousin read the lectionary, had walked the length of the train at the first water stop and come back moist-eyed with admiration: “The brakes *charge the bat-*

teries, Captain. Wickedness wasted nothing either. Nice to see thrift catch up.”

What the country had been was also on view, because the Consolidated line did not hide it, and that was policy too. Outside Baltimore the train slid past the first of the transformer graveyards — four acres of them, the great burned hulks of the old grid hauled off their pads and set in rows on gravel, each with its small steel plate: substation name, date of death, which was almost always one of two dates in October 2064. The Compact kept the grass cut. School groups came. Ruth had been nine or ten when the practice started, and had asked her father why anyone would keep the broken things where people could see them, and he had thought about it for most of a mile of buggy ride and said: “So nobody has to argue about what happened.”

Amos followed her eyes and said nothing for a while. Then: “My cousin’s district lost four hundred souls that first winter. English souls, I mean. On the roads.” He rubbed his thumb along the window rail. “My father fed some. Buried some. He’d never say the numbers. He’d only say, *we were spared for the spending.*” He glanced at her. “That’s in the Fold now, you know. They folded it right in. *Spared for the spending.* Sits between a line of Isaiah and something Sotho, I’m told, and fits both.”

South of Richmond the land opened and the century showed its working. Mesh-steeple towns: every county seat with its lattice tower, the shared-dictionary relays that had been the whole of the continent’s telephone system for a decade and were still its bones, hung now with festival lights for the harvest like the church spires they had half-replaced and half-become. Compact granaries at the division points, brick and proud as courthouses. Assist frames in the tobacco fields — the thin silver exoskeletons moving down the rows at a worker’s own pace, muscle without engine, the one machine the Plain districts had voted to call *tool* and take into their own fields. Her mother wore one now for the milking, at seventy-one. The Ordnung deliberations of 2067 had run four months and ended, famously, in nine words from an Ephrata bishop: “*It does not separate. It only carries. Let it.*”

And twice, far off, the other inheritance: Guardian frames, the heavy ones, hull-shouldered and scarred, one walking a bridge truss into place on the Roanoke line, one standing in a rail yard with its arms

full of pipe like a patient uncle. Every child in the North grew up on the picture books — the Frames digging Chicago out, the Frames holding the Memphis levee, the Frame at some flooded gallery on the far side of the world that held a roof for eleven hours, which even the American books told, because the story had gone where all the best stories go, into everyone's inheritance at once.

"You've gone quiet, Captain," Amos said, somewhere in North Carolina.

"Counting," Ruth said.

"Ledger can wait for evening."

"Not that count." She nodded at the window, at the fields, at the whole worked and working land. "General asked me what the gold is. Payment, tribute, offering. I keep looking for what we'd be paying *for*." The train ran on a long embankment; below it, a solar farm turned its thousand faces southwest together, slow as sunflowers. "Everything out there we built ourselves. Their technique's in the batteries, all right. One step, the treaty says. Everything else was us: the mesh was a dead man's gift, the frames were mining rescue, the struts are physics my grandfather would've allowed on a Tuesday. We didn't buy this century from them, Amos. We grew it. So what in the world are we buying?"

Amos considered it with the full gravity he gave a bad manifest. "Then maybe it's not buying," he said. "You pay rent, too, on land you didn't make. And tithe on a harvest you did." He shrugged. "And there's a third thing it could be, that the general didn't list."

"Which is?"

"Seed corn." He said it plainly and would not be drawn further, because it was a fourteen-hour run to Savannah and Amos Beiler portioned out his wisdom like winter feed.

The port of embarkation had been Savannah once and was now mostly a new thing grown beside the old town: the Atlantic freight basin, treaty-neutral ground, where the Southern Carry lines met the northern rail and the world's slow ships came and went on the world's slow schedules. The consignment's freighter stood at the deep berth — the *Karoo Dawn*, Cape-flagged, four hundred metres of sail-hybrid with her rigid wings feathered and her wave-flex skin

rippling gently at the waterline, drinking the harbour chop and turning it into house current, a ship that fed on weather the way the whole century fed on everything: frugally, constantly, without drama.

And above the basin, on the bluff where the old port authority had been, Ruth got her first sight of the century's one piece of drama — the thing the schedules called HEAVY LIFT and everyone else called by its right name. An e-grav gantry, walking a platcap bank the size of a house down the bluff to the water: the crystalline rotor stack in its belly spun up to a note she felt in her back teeth rather than heard, the forty-tonne load riding under it at a weight the readout on the gantry's flank cheerfully declared to be twenty-six and falling, the whole assembly stepping down the grade slow and sure-footed as a deacon carrying the font. The stevedores didn't look up. Ruth looked up the whole time, coin against her breast pocket, thinking, not for the first time, that her grandmother had been born into a world where this was impossible, and had died in one where it was merely expensive.

"Manifests," said Amos, materialising at her elbow with the boarding packet, "are complete, Captain. Two hundred forty ton, eight hundred twelve boxes, every seal green, and the ship's master says we sail on the evening tide, which he says like the tide works for him, so I expect we sail when the tide's good and ready."

"Thank you, Sergeant."

He followed her gaze up to the gantry, to the impossible readout. "My father would call that pride," he said comfortably. "Lifting a thing by lying to it about its weight."

"Your father would ride it to the barn roof inside a week."

"He would," Amos agreed. "He'd repent after."

They went up the gangway in the long gold evening, the last American ground going strange and small under the ship's height, and Ruth stood at the rail through the unmooring the way she'd stood at every threshold of her life, counting. Behind her, the burned and rebuilt interior, the graveyards mowed like memory, the meshes singing their small songs over the fields, her mother's Assist frame folded by a dairy door, four hundred years of her people being exactly where they stood. Ahead, five thousand miles of grey Atlantic, and at the far side

of it the one country that never burned, and a berth called Nine, and the invoice nobody had ever seen.

Seed corn, she thought, and put it in the evening's ledger under *taken in*, and went below.

Chapter 5 — The Custodial Brake

eGoli Spaceport · five weeks to Renewal

The Commissioner's office sent a car, which Naledi declined, and a follow-up note saying the Commissioner entirely understood and would she prefer the port canteen, which was how she learned the first true thing about Dr. Sefako Marais: he did his homework, and his homework told him she'd rather meet where the tea was bad and the ground was hers.

He was waiting at a corner table at oh-seven-hundred with two cups and no aides, a broad grey man in a suit the colour of good concrete, and he stood to shake her hand like she was the appointment he'd been looking forward to, which, she reminded herself, was a skill.

"Engineer Mokoena. Thank you for the hour. I know what shift-change costs." He sat, nudged the better cup toward her, and put a printout of her ledger application on the table between them, face up, unbothered, like a man laying down a card he respected. "This is fine work."

"It's an application, Commissioner. The fine work is sealed."

"Ha." It was a real laugh, brief. "So it is. Let me do this the way you'd want it done, then — no fog." He turned the printout to face her and tapped the grounds paragraph. "One: your curve is probably real. My office ran your public numbers past two people I trust; they couldn't break it. Two: your application will be denied." He said it exactly as evenly as everything else. "Not by me — the Stewards hold the key, and the Council moves at the speed of stone. But the Port Authority countersign comes through this office, and I will not be

providing it before the Renewal. I wanted you to hear that from my mouth, with my reasons, instead of from a form letter. You've earned the reasons."

"Which are?"

"Arithmetic." He wrapped both hands around his cup. "You know what I did before this? I ran disaster logistics. Blackout Decade. I moved grain on a continent with no fuel and sixty governments' worth of paperwork, and the thing that job burns into you is that being right about a question is worth nothing — *nothing*, Engineer — next to being ready for its answer. You have found a real question. I believe you. Now walk it forward with me: I countersign, the Council deliberates in its own good time, and meanwhile the fact of the request — which is already on your ledger for the world to read, and they are reading it, my office counts newsfeed reads too — becomes the Renewal's centrepiece. Forty delegations arrive not to sign a treaty but to relitigate twenty-nine years of consignments. The Keep bloc gets a flag. The Give bloc gets a panic. And the counterparty, who have never once answered a question we had no standing to ask, get asked it with the whole species watching — six weeks before the only signature that matters." He turned his cup a quarter-turn. "We can be curious for the next twenty-seven years, Engineer Mokoena. We can be *sovereign* for the next six weeks. I know how that sentence sounds. I've had thirty years to get comfortable with how my sentences sound. It's still the right arithmetic."

The canteen filled and emptied around them, grey coats and freight tabards. Naledi drank her bad tea and gave herself a moment, the way the interview had taught her long ago: *read the tolerance before you read the intent*.

"Your arithmetic has a suppressed term," she said.

"Show me."

"Volume." She set her cup down. "The amendment on the Renewal table raises consignment volume. Everyone knows it; it's the whole agenda. So the choice isn't *ask now or ask in twenty-seven years*. The choice is: ask while the question is small, or sign first and triple the flow of the thing we didn't ask about — and then ask, from underneath it. Waiting isn't neutral, Commissioner. Waiting is a position. It's the Give position, wearing patience as a coat."

Marais looked at her for a long moment, and something in his face rearranged — not displeasure; inventory. It occurred to her that people did not often show him their working.

“You’d have done well in grain,” he said. He gathered the printout, squared it, and stood. “The countersign answer is still no. But I’m going to do two things a form letter wouldn’t. First: after signature, I will co-file your disclosure application myself — this office, your name and mine together, and the Council can move at the speed of stone with a commissioner sitting on the stone. My word, on the ledger by end of day, where you keep your things.” He meant it, she could see, which was somehow the most alarming part of the whole hour. “Second: a Renewal season needs its best people visible. I’m recommending you to Dlamini as tuning liaison for the American consignment when it berths. Where the delegations can watch South African verification at work.”

Where everyone can watch the flag risk stand in the light with her hands full, Naledi translated, and said, “Thank you, Commissioner,” and meant about a third of it.

He paused at the door, because men like him always had a door line. “For what it’s worth, Engineer — I hope you’re wrong about the margin. But I’ve read your grounds paragraph six times now. *Good faith deserves good measurement*.” He tapped the doorframe once. “If the world were run by verification techs, we’d deserve it sooner. Good morning.”

He was gone before she could decide whether she’d been complimented, recruited, or outflanked, and by mid-shift she knew the answer was all three, which was her first full lesson in why nobody had ever beaten Sefako Marais at anything.

—

The second visitor found her at end of shift, in the refinery row, and made no appointment at all.

She noticed him because he was the only stillness on the catwalk: a young man in the Stewards’ undyed robe, too young for it by every association the robe carried, standing at the rail above the evening pour exactly where Baba Sipho had stood a week ago. Watching not the gold. Her terminal, dark under her arm. Then her.

“Engineer Mokoena.” He said her name like a man returning something she’d dropped. “Tefo. I won’t hold you. The Council received your application.”

“And will move at the speed of stone. I’ve had the weather report.”

“Mm. Stone moves,” Tefo said. “Ask the Vredefort dome.” Below them the pour ran gold light up the walls, and he watched it with an expression she couldn’t file: not reverence, exactly. Grief’s younger cousin. “I’m not here from the Council. If anyone asks, I’m not here at all — you’d be surprised how good the robe is for that; people record the robe and forget the man. I came because of the deposit note.”

Her stomach went quiet. “You’ve read my access trail.”

“No. I read the same note you did, four years ago, and I’ve been waiting since to see whose name showed up next to it.” He turned from the rail and faced her properly, and up close he was her own age, with the eyes of a man who had been losing an argument politely for a long time. “*D. Mokoena attending*. The survey engineer. The Council speaks of her the way they speak of the founding generation — which is to say, in the past tense, and carefully. She carried the series in, Engineer. Twelve hundred hours of the deep record, everything the waking was, sealed on her survey handover — and there is a thing about that seal that even your very complete application doesn’t know to ask.” He glanced along the catwalk, an unhurried habit of a glance, and lowered his voice not at all, which she would later understand was the tradecraft of a man who knew that whispering is what recordings listen for. “Everyone assumes the Stewards sealed it. Look again at the countersign order, if your grade shows you metadata. The Authority sealed it *at the surveyor’s written insistence*. Condition of handover. Her hand, her clause. The Council keeps the key because your grandmother would not hand the series over any other way.”

The pour ended. The moulds ticked. Somewhere below, a foreman called numbers in isiZulu, and the great room went on being the world.

“Why,” Naledi said, and found her voice had gone down to bearings and datum points, “would a surveyor seal her own survey away from her own guild?”

“That,” said Tefo, “is the first question I’ve heard anyone at this port ask in four years that the Renewal can’t answer.” He drew the robe’s hood up, which somehow made him more anonymous rather than less, exactly as he’d said. “The Council will deny you, Engineer, this season and probably next. The order is old and frightened and right about more than it can say. But orders are made of people, and some of us think two hundred years of silence has begun to protect the silence instead of the thing.” He was three steps down the catwalk when he turned, and gave her the rest the way you hand over a load — squarely, watching her take the weight.

“What did she leave off the map, do you think?”

Then the robe went down the stairs into the shift-change crowd and was, as advertised, nothing but a robe among coats, and Naledi Mokoena stood above the cooling gold with her dark terminal under her arm, aware that the day had handed her three doors: one closed kindly, one closed politely, and one, somewhere four kilometres under her family’s own signed and public and incomplete maps, that had never been closed at all — because it had never been drawn.

Chapter 6 — The Crossing

South Atlantic, aboard Karoo Dawn · four weeks to Renewal

The sea kept its own ledger.

Ruth learned the ship's rhythms inside three days, the way you learn any post: the wings trimming themselves along the wind with a sound like a barn settling, the wave-flex skin running its slow shivers down the hull — the mate called it *the shrug* — every swell that struck them paying a toll into the cells, storm chop worth more than fair weather, so that the crew, in the oldest sailor grammar there was, had come to speak of weather as money. “Rich night coming,” the bosun would say, tapping the glass, and mean eleven metres and a gale.

The gold rode amidships in a hold with three seal systems and one Army cot, and the cot was ceremonial — Amos had inspected the hold, pronounced it tighter than any granary in Lancaster County, and moved the watch rotation to the door, where a man could at least see weather. Ruth stood her own watches. It wasn't required. It was what she had instead of the count coming out even.

On the sixth night, somewhere over the mid-Atlantic ridge with the aurora faint and green to the south — you could see it most clear nights now, the sun still restless, the sky's old threat turned almanac — Amos brought two mugs to the hold door and set one on the coaming at her elbow and stood drinking his in the dark, which was Beiler for *I'll listen if it wants out*.

It had been wanting out for nineteen years.

“Bottomland harvest, eighty-one,” Ruth said, to the sea more than to him. “You'd have been — what. Twelve.”

“Eleven. I remember it, though. Everyone in the districts remembers it.” He blew on his tea. “You’d know better than the stories.”

“I was the stories.” She wrapped both hands around the mug the way Marais of eGoli, whom she had never met, wrapped his — the habit of people who have learned to give their hands something to do that isn’t shaking. “Second lieutenant, first posting, Susquehanna flood detail. We had four thousand acres of winter grain in the bottomland and a warm week coming off the mountains, and the Corps model said the levees held and the window was nine days. Move the harvest convoys in, lift the grain, everybody home dry. The model had satellite weather, river gauges, sixty years of hydrology. It was a good model.” The shrug ran down the hull, long and slow, and paid its toll. “And there was an elder at the staging barn — Yoder, white beard to his belt, farmed that bottomland fifty years — and he stood in front of my convoy with his hat in his hands, polite as a funeral, and said the ground didn’t agree. Said the frost was out of the far bank too early and the ice meadows upstream were going, and when they went, they went all at once, and nine days was a city man’s number. Asked me — didn’t tell me, *asked* me — to hold the convoys on the high road one more day while his boys walked the banks.”

“And the model said nine days,” Amos said quietly.

“The model said nine days, and my captain said the model said nine days, and I had the order in my hand.” She drank. The tea had gone the temperature of the sea. “I gave Yoder every respect. I remember being proud of how much respect I gave him — parked half the convoy on the shoulder of the high road, kept the loading crews staged instead of camped. Split the difference. You know what splitting the difference is, Sergeant, when one side of the difference is water?”

Amos said nothing, which was the right answer.

“Ice dam let go up at Conowago in the small hours. The river came up eleven feet in forty minutes. We got everyone off the flats that we could raise on the mesh — and the mesh worked, mesh always works, that’s the bitter miracle of it, every soul we lost heard the alert just fine. They were forty minutes from high ground with grain trucks axle-deep in a field going to porridge.” She set the mug down on the coaming, carefully, dead level. “Eleven souls, Amos. Six of them

mine to move. Board of inquiry called the order sound based on available modelling, called the loss weather, commended the evacuation. My captain made major on schedule. And Elder Yoder came to the memorial — came to *me*, at the memorial, hat in his hands the exact same way — and you know what he said?”

“I’d guess he said it wasn’t yours.”

“He said, *‘The river was going to do what the river did. But child — next time, believe somebody.’*” Her voice didn’t break, which she’d had nineteen years of practice at. “Not *believe me*. Believe *somebody*. Like the failure wasn’t picking the wrong knowledge. It was thinking the choosing was mine to skip.”

The aurora breathed, far south. The ship shrugged, and earned.

“Everyone at home thinks I stayed in the Army because I left the faith,” Ruth said. “I stayed in because of the opposite thing. Because there’s always going to be an order and a Yoder, and there ought to be one soul in the room who’s stood where both of them stand. Somebody who knows what wrong orders cost should be the one carrying them. That’s the whole of my theology, Sergeant. The Fold got it down to two sentences and I still needed nineteen years and a flood.”

Amos was quiet for a proper while, Beiler-quiet, the kind with work going on inside it.

“You know what this run is, then,” he said at last.

“Say it anyway.”

“It’s the bottomland again, writ big as the world.” He nodded forward, at the hold, at the boxes that did not look like anything. “There’s a model — twenty-nine years of manifests that never once lied, that’s a good model, Captain, best mankind ever had of a stranger. And somewhere down south there’ll be a Yoder. Some soul who’s walked the banks and says the ground doesn’t agree. And the whole species is going to be standing where you stood, with the order in its hand and nine days on the clock.” He drained his mug and turned it upside down on the coaming, done. “Be a mercy on everybody if the officer in the room’s already made that mistake once, and cheap.”

“Cheap,” Ruth said. “Eleven souls.”

“Against the world, Captain,” said Amos Beiler, gently, “that’s cheap. Which is a hateful kind of sum, and why quartermasters keep the books and God keeps the accounts.” He straightened off the bulkhead. “Deck watch says a rich night coming. I’d sleep now if I were you.”

She didn’t sleep. She stood the rest of the watch at the hold door doing the thing the Fold called folding it in: taking the day’s weight and finding where it sat in the two sentences. It sat, like most things, in the gap between them — *don’t be a cunt* was easy, nineteen years easy; it was *be kind* that had teeth, because kind wasn’t soft, kind was Yoder holding his hat, kind was telling a lieutenant the truth at a memorial, kind was whatever it was going to cost some tuning engineer at eGoli — she did not yet know the name — to stand in front of the species’ nine-day window and say the ground didn’t agree.

Toward the end of the watch the storm came up out of the southwest, and the *Karoo Dawn* leaned into it and began, in her patient centennial way, to get rich. Ruth Stoltzfus stood in the noise with her hand on her breast pocket and let the sea have the rest of the count.

Eight days later, at dawn, the lookout’s whistle went, and she came up on deck into cold clean light and saw it lifted over the horizon like the lid of the world: Table Mountain, and the green land under it that had never once gone dark — and, hanging silver and vast in the high blue north of it, too far to be anything and too still to be nothing, the first visitor hull of her life, riding down the sky toward the interior slow as a lowered flag.

Around her the crew kept working. It was just the world.

“Well,” said Amos at the rail, hat in his hands, in the voice his people saved for weather and Scripture. “Now we find out.”

Chapter 7 — Liaison

eGoli Spaceport · three and a half weeks to Renewal

The assignment order was posted on the guild board at shift-change, where assignment orders had always been posted, because Baba Sipho held that a guild that stopped reading its own wall was a guild that deserved what the newsfeeds told it instead.

Consignment 100-USA-Renewal. Tuning liaison: MOKOENA, N. Effective on berthing.

“Congratulations,” said Mothusi, reading over her shoulder with his tea, “or condolences. I genuinely can’t tell anymore. That’s the flag consignment. That’s forty cameras.”

“It’s a leash,” Naledi said. “It’s a very well-made leash.”

“It’s a Marais,” Mothusi agreed. “My uncle dealt with him in the grain years. He says the Commissioner’s the only man in Africa who can promote you and bury you in the same signature and make both feel like weather.”

The liaison brief came with an office — an actual office, on the gallery level, with a window that looked west across the apron to where the rotor-anomaly testbed ran its patient cycles — and with a schedule of protocol sessions she had never rated before, because a flag consignment’s tuning liaison did her verification in front of the counterparty’s own liaison, and the counterparty’s own liaison was Sela.

Everyone at the port knew Sela the way everyone knows a lighthouse: by position and regularity, from a distance, without the least sense of acquaintance. The treaty name was human-made — some committee in the seventies had needed syllables that forty languages

could pronounce, and the visitors had accepted them the way they accepted everything human, with a courtesy that closed over the question like water over a stone. What stood at the protocol table on the day of Naledi's first session was tall past usefulness of the word, robed in a fabric that behaved like fabric right up until it didn't, and present in the particular way the hulls were present: without hurry, without weight, with an attention you could feel on your skin like barometric pressure.

The session ran ninety minutes and was, for eighty-seven of them, the most boring meeting of her career. That was the discipline nobody warned you about. Twenty-nine years of contact had produced not wonder but *procedure* — schedules, tolerances, formats for the exchange of formats — and the visitors inhabited procedure the way whales inhabit water, completely, gratefully almost, as if the entire architecture of treaty and manifest were a gift the species had given them rather than a fence it had built in its own terror. They went line by line through the American consignment's pre-arrival documentation. Sela's voice was low, even, perfectly grammatical, and had underneath it a texture she had no file for, like a second voice a quarter-tone down saying the same words a half-syllable late.

At minute eighty-eight, Naledi asked her question.

She had built it the way she built everything, to tolerance. Not the sealed series — that was ledger business, human business. Not the curve. Something smaller, adjacent, completely inside her liaison remit, and aimed, like a survey shot, at a bearing only she would know to check.

"A verification matter," she said. "Manifest line forty: the declared purity band for the American consignment is narrower than repair schedule nine requires. Nine-nines-four, where the schedule's own tolerance admits nine-nines-one. We verify to what's declared, so the tighter band costs my guild triple the assay time." She laid it down as flatly as a coupling reading. "Why this purity?"

The pause was three seconds. She counted it, because counting was what she had instead of a heartbeat she could trust just then, and she would put the number in her private notes that evening: *three full seconds*, from an interlocutor whose every previous response in eighty-eight minutes had come back in under one.

“The declared band is within schedule,” Sela said.

“Within, yes. Narrower than. My question is why.”

“Precision,” said Sela, in that voice like two voices agreeing, “is respect,” and moved to line forty-one with a courtesy so seamless that it took Naledi the rest of the session to be sure of what had happened — that she had asked the first question in twenty-nine years of her guild’s protocol record to receive an answer that was true, beautiful, and *not an answer*, and that something behind the fabric that behaved like fabric had chosen it that way, in three seconds, the way a tuner chooses a note.

Precision is respect. She wrote it at the top of her notes that night and stared at it. It was the sort of thing the guild itself said. It was the sort of thing the founding manuals said, in the dry unnamed voice. It would look perfect on the wall of the choir room, and it told her precisely nothing, and it told her everything, because you do not reach for a proverb to deflect a question about assay time. You reach for a proverb when the true answer is one sentence long and you have decided not to say it.

The purity band wasn’t for repair. Repair forgave. Whatever the American gold was for needed nine-nines-four the way an instrument needs it, and there was exactly one thing in her world that got tuned to bands like that.

She was still staring at the sentence when the office window did the thing that windows at eGoli did at night: filled, slowly, with the testbed’s glow. Across the dark apron the anomaly rig was running its long cycle, the crystalline rotor spun up and charged, hanging its handspan above the cradle in its cage of instruments — and beyond it, three berths down, the resident hull at Berth Six sat in its own version of the same stillness, vast and unweighted, riding the world’s oldest open secret. She had grown up on the joke — *ours hums, theirs doesn’t* — and had stopped hearing it years ago, the way port children stopped hearing the choir. Tonight she heard it. Nobody in forty governments knew why the rotor got light. The visitors had been asked, in the polite early years, and had declined, politely, totally. The two stillnesses stood a kilometre apart in the dark, obviously, insultingly related, like a proverb and its missing sentence.

Precision is respect. And silence, she thought, was also something,

and she was starting to assemble a hypothesis about what.

Her terminal chimed. Two messages.

The first was from the guild boards, routine: the *Karoo Dawn* had cleared Cape Agulhas and made her river of the rail slot; the American consignment would berth in five days. Attached, the consignment officer's manifest signature, which she looked at longer than she needed to, because she had developed opinions about signatures lately. *R. Stoltzfus, Capt., USA-LC*. Small, upright, no flourish at all — a hand that had been taught by people who thought a signature was a promise rather than a performance, and had believed them.

The second message had no routing header her grade could see, which should not have been possible on the guild system, and was one line long.

The two that were halted were both nine-nines-four. — T.

Naledi sat very still for a long time, in her leashed office, in the glow of the two stillnesses, holding her three facts the way her grandmother must once have held a theodolite in a gallery nobody would ever survey again: the pitch was always the same pitch. The band was always the same band. And the only two times in twenty-nine years that anyone had said *no* to the machine on the far side of all this courtesy, the *no* had come from the old order that kept her grandmother's seal — and the gold they stopped had been tuned like the gold on eight hundred and twelve boxes now five days out from Berth Nine, riding toward her under the signature of a captain who kept promises.

She opened her private notes and wrote the hypothesis at last, in survey language, all bearings, no adjectives, because writing it made it real and real was the only direction she knew how to walk.

The manifests describe maintenance. The tolerances describe an instrument. Somewhere in the network something is being brought to concert pitch, and the reference — the pitch they are tuning to — is here.

Chapter 8 — Berth Nine

eGoli Spaceport · three weeks to Renewal

The American gold came up from the coast on the treaty rail, under escort, in the polished light of a highveld winter morning, and eGoli did what eGoli did for a flag consignment: it put on its manners.

Naledi watched the arrival from the gallery above Berth Nine with the liaison packet under her arm and the port arranging itself below her like a demonstration of the century. The treaty train sliding in under the old headgear, which the port had kept and painted and lit, so that every consignment arrived framed by the bones of the mine it used to be. The honour detail. The press stand, forty cameras exactly as promised. And walking down from the lead car ahead of the boxes, in a dress uniform the colour of turned earth, a compact woman with a sergeant at her shoulder like a standing stone, who paused at the foot of the ramp, looked up — not at the cameras, not at the headgear, but along the full length of the berth rails, the way a farmer reads a fence line — and then came on.

“Engineer Mokoena.” The handshake was dry and brief and the eyes did the thing the signature had promised: looked at you once, completely, and filed you. “Ruth Stoltzfus. Consignment officer. This is Sergeant Beiler; the manifest lives in his head, the copies are for everyone else.” Up close, the accent was strange and plain at once, vowels from somewhere old. “I’m told you’re the one who checks whether we did it right.”

“I’m the one who checks whether it’s what it says it is,” Naledi said.

“Same church, different pew,” said the sergeant, comfortably.

The verification of a flag consignment was theatre, and then it was

work, and the theatre came first: the ceremonial first box opened on a draped table for the cameras, the assay sample drawn with tongs older than the Accord, Marais presiding at just enough distance to be in every frame and no decision. Naledi did her part with her mother's patience and her grandmother's face. Then the press were walked to lunch, the berth doors rolled down, and the work began: eight hundred and twelve boxes, two hundred and forty tonnes, every tenth box opened per protocol, the resonance rig run against each sampled geometry, profile by profile, while Captain Stoltzfus stood attending as consignment officer — not hovering; *attending*, present the way the choir was present, and after the first hour Naledi stopped performing composure and just worked, which she would realise later was the American's gift: she was restful, the way level ground is restful.

The profiles began to stack on her screen. Box after box, geometry after geometry, nine-nines-four and beautiful — Compact refinery work, hand-finished, provenance-perfect, the finest consignment stock she had ever put on the rig.

And clean. That was the thing. That was the terrible generous thing.

Every consignment she'd flagged before had carried its offset buried in ordinary industrial noise — you needed three sigma of patience and a suspicious mind. The American gold had no noise. Whoever had worked it had worked it with the fanatic honesty of people who believed the load was going before God, and the result stood on her screen like a witness taking the oath: the offset, whole, coherent, undeniable, in every sampled box. Energy disciplined toward the same spectral line as 100-409, 100-412, 100-417. The pitch that was always the same pitch. Not a curve anymore. A chord.

She ran the eleventh sample twice, which she never did, and heard behind her, quiet and level:

"Captain's question, Engineer. Is that wrong?"

Naledi looked at the screen for a moment. Forty cameras away at lunch, a Commissioner composing the afternoon's photographs, her guild-master's word waiting kindly on the ledger like a lid; and at her shoulder, attending, the one person on this apron who had signed the same line she was about to sign.

"It's not wrong," she said. "It's undeclared."

She heard the sergeant stop counting boxes.

“Say that,” said Captain Stoltzfus, “the way you’d say it to a quartermaster.”

So she said it the way she’d say it to a quartermaster, and it took four minutes, because stripped of the archive politics and the sealed series and her grandmother, it was four minutes long: manifests declare repair; repair is broadband; this is narrow, coherent, common-referenced across consignments and now across continents; narrow-band discipline means tuning; tuning means a reference; the reference tolerance is written into your own purity band; your gold conforms to the manifest and the manifest does not describe what your gold is *for*. She laid the profiles side by side on the screen, the American chord over the archive curve, and stood aside the way you stand aside from a survey scope, and let the captain look.

Ruth Stoltzfus looked for a long time. What moved in her face was not shock; it was something Naledi had no name for yet and would have said, if pressed, looked like a woman recognising terrain.

“Twenty-nine years of manifests that never once lied,” the captain said, at last, mostly to herself, “and here’s the ground, not agreeing.” She straightened up. “What do you need, Engineer, that you don’t have?”

“A baseline. The only telemetry that can norm this is sealed — custodial, 2064. My application’s on the ledger. It’ll be denied till after signature. After signature, the volume amendment triples the flow.” Naledi shrugged, exactly once, the shrug of the whole six weeks. “What I need is standing. I’m a tech with a curve. Curves die in locked rooms. It’s been made clear to me, kindly, by people I respect, that this is the wrong season to be right.”

“Mm,” said the captain, in a tone that made the sergeant, across the berth, look up like a man hearing distant weather. She was quiet a moment. Then: “Two hundred and forty tonnes of my country’s good faith is sampled on your rig, Engineer, and you’re telling me the invoice doesn’t say what it’s for. I was sent five thousand miles to answer exactly one question, and you have just told me nobody on this continent can answer it either. So.” She unbuttoned her breast pocket, took out a pen that had signed either everything or nothing, Naledi couldn’t tell, and nodded at the verification console. “Protocol

says the consignment officer witnesses the verification record. Print the whole of it. Your profiles, your overlay, your assessment language — the four minutes, in writing. If it's on the record I witnessed, it's not a tech's curve anymore. It's a treaty document with two flags on it, and they can close a guild file, Engineer, but I'd genuinely like to watch them try to close an American one."

"They'll call it a provocation," Naledi said. "Three weeks before signature. Commissioner Marais—"

"Commissioner Marais," said Ruth Stoltzfus, "isn't in my chain of command, and my orders say *render assistance as required*. I've read them a lot of times. There's no season clause." Something surfaced in the plain face then, one degree of warmth, like the first lamp in a window at dusk. "Nineteen years ago a man with more sense than my whole chain of command asked me to believe somebody, and I split the difference, and I have carried the arithmetic ever since. I'm not splitting this one. Print your record, Engineer Mokoena. I'll sign it."

Naledi printed it. The rig chattered; the pages came up warm.

At sixteen forty-one, three weeks to the day before the Great Renewal, in the closed berth under the painted headgear, verification record 100-USA-R/1 went onto the treaty ledger over two signatures: *N. Mokoena, Tuning Guild, eGoli* — and below it, small and upright and without any flourish at all, the hand of a woman keeping a promise to a dead elder five thousand miles from the river that taught her:

Witnessed: R. Stoltzfus, Capt., US Army Logistics Corps, for the Plain Compact and the United States. The ground does not agree. Recommend we believe somebody.

The sergeant read the second sentence over her shoulder, and looked at his captain, and put his hat back on.

"Well," said Amos Beiler, to the gold, to the berth, to the three weeks. "Now it's freight."

Chapter 9 — Reasonable Men

eGoli Spaceport · three weeks to Renewal

The record went onto the ledger at sixteen forty-one. The world had read it by supper.

By morning it had a name — the newsfeeds, with the infallible instinct of their trade, had found the four warmest words in nine pages of assessment language and led with them: **THE GROUND DOES NOT AGREE**. By the second morning it had a market reaction, two parliamentary questions in Pretoria and one in Canberra, a Keep-bloc communiqué “noting with appreciation the integrity of the eGoli verification process,” a Give-bloc editorial calling it “a three-sigma tantrum at a species wedding,” and a mesh-hymn — someone in the Compact zones had set the second sentence to a tune already, *recommend we believe somebody*, four-part, the way that century made everything four-part.

What it did not have, anywhere in it, was a lie, and Naledi came to understand over those days that this was precisely the problem she had created for reasonable men. A lie could be corrected. A provocation could be condemned. A true, procedurally impeccable treaty document with two flags on it could only be *managed*, and the port began to manage it around her with a smoothness that would have been beautiful to watch happening to someone else.

Her night access to the archive annex was “rationalised” — a Renewal-season security posture, the notice said, applying to all non-essential grades, and when she checked, it did apply to all non-essential grades; they had simply redrawn essential around her

like a chalk outline. The consignment verification records adjacent to her curve — 409, 412, 417 — were “administratively sequestered pending conference review,” which meant nothing was deleted and everything was behind a door with a committee for a handle. Her protocol sessions with Sela continued, line-perfect; a second guild observer now attended each one, young, apologetic, and never the same twice, and their notes went somewhere hers didn’t.

Nobody raised a voice. Nobody threatened. Files just closed ahead of her wherever she walked, softly, like doors in a house where someone was sleeping.

“You have to admire it,” Mothusi said, low, at the console line. “It’s not even malice. It’s craft.” He had copied her closed discrepancy flag to his own log the day the record went public — so had one other tuner, Ayanda from the night choir, both of them without a word to her — three small acts of professional witness sitting on the guild record now like stones on a coffin lid, and all three flags had been closed by the same abbreviated signature within the hour. Baba Siphos wax thumbprint, three times.

She went to him. She owed him that, and she was angry enough to pay it.

She found him where the guild always found him in a bad week, in the choir loft above Berth Six, listening to the resident hull tick, and he heard her out — the accesses, the sequestrations, the chalk outline — with his hands folded on the rail, an old man in a grey coat under eleven hundred tonnes of patience.

“Everything you have described,” he said when she finished, “crossed my desk, and most of it carries my signature.” He said it the way he’d said *it was my hand*: no shelter taken. “You put a treaty document on the world ledger without bringing it to your guild-master first, my child. Not because you feared I’d forbid it. Because you knew I’d be obliged to.” He looked at her sideways. “That was correctly reasoned, by the way. I would have been.”

“And now?”

“Now I sign the paperwork that manages you, because if my hand is on it, other hands aren’t, and the other hands available this season have fewer scruples about young engineers than mine.” The hull

ticked. Far below, freight went about the world's business. "You've read the old manuals. The founding voice — the epigraph hand. There's a line of hers the cadet syllabus doesn't include. *When the system protects itself instead of the work, the discrepancy has moved up a level.*" He let that sit exactly long enough. "Note the diagnosis, Naledi. Then note that she wrote *the system*, not *the people*. The people are your colleagues who copied your flag, and a commissioner who has slept four hours a night since the grain years so that other people could be idealists inside a fed perimeter, and an old man who is trying to keep his best tuner attached to the guild that will still need her the morning after the treaty. Do not let the newsfeeds teach you that the door-closers are a species. It's the season leaning on everyone, and everyone creaking where they're weakest."

"And where do you creak, Baba?"

"Loyalty," said Baba Sipho Dlamini, without hesitating, and put his hands back on the rail.

The delegations' reception that evening was held in the concourse under the mesh-lattice ceiling, forty flags and a thousand lanyards, and Naledi attended because liaison staff attended, and stood at the edge of it with a glass of wine she didn't drink, watching the species negotiate with itself. She had expected to despise it and found she couldn't manage anything so clean. The Give bloc was not a slogan up close; it was the delegate from Bangladesh, whose grandmother's coastline the platcap seawalls had held, saying *whatever they are, the relationship is the only power grid we have* — and it was the Chinese delegation's quiet, ferocious lead negotiator, who had rebuilt a sixth of her country on licensed cells, remarking to a circle of small nations that goodwill from a superior power was the only security that had ever existed, ask anyone who had lived beside anyone. The Keep bloc was the Chilean custodial minister with the burn-line tattooed on his forearm — his own grid's date of death — saying *we kept the lights on by owning our own ground, and we will not lease the planet's basement to a courteous stranger*. Everyone was right. That was the sickening physics of it. Everyone was standing on a true thing, gesturing at a dark thing, and the dark thing did not gesture back; it berthed at Six and paid its freight and waited, patient as procedure.

She was leaving when she saw the old man.

He was at the far margin of the reception where the catering met the freight corridor, in a suit that had been very good two decades ago, arguing with a gate clerk in the low furious voice of a man rationing his dignity — something about a pass, a list, a name that should have been on it. Seventy-something, straight-backed, West African by his accent's bones. The clerk's face had the fixed patience of a man following a script, and the script was winning; the old man gathered himself, turned from the desk, and for one second his eyes crossed Naledi's across the concourse — took in the guild grey, the liaison tag — and she watched him *recognise* her, the way people had started to, since the ledger.

He didn't approach. That was the thing she carried home. Every other stranger that week had approached. The old man in the twenty-year-old suit looked at her, and something went across his face like grief remembering its manners — and he inclined his head, once, the smallest bow in the world, one professional to another, and walked away toward the transit hall with his refused pass in his fist.

"Who was that?" she asked the clerk, on her way out.

The clerk checked his script, and evidently found the name harmless enough to share with a lanyard. "Nobody, Engineer. Retired. He applies every conference — wants access to the delegates' technical annex. Says he has material for the record." He shrugged, boxing up the evening. "Okonkwo Diri. Used to be one of the space men. You know. From *before*."

Her terminal, in her pocket, chimed once against her hip as she stepped out under the winter stars — the message header dark to her grade, the text one line long, and the first thing in three weeks to make her stand still on the concourse steps and smile, slowly, like a tuner hearing a note come true.

The Council will see you. Bring the curve, and wear boots. — T.

Chapter 10 — Sunday at the Port

eGoli Spaceport · two and three-quarter weeks to Renewal

Sunday found the port the way Sunday found everywhere now, which was the thing about the Fold that Ruth had never managed to explain to the last of the old aunts: it did not interrupt the world. It surfaced through it.

The service was held in the main concourse at the hour the berths ran quietest, under the mesh-lattice ceiling, and the congregation assembled itself out of the port's own population the way a tide pool fills: freight crews still in tabards, choir tuners coming off shift, delegation staff of forty flags, a knot of Chilean custodial officers, cleaning staff with their carts parked in a companionable rank at the back. No pulpit. A reader's stand, and the day's reader — rotation, always rotation; this week a Kenyan rail engineer with a slow deep voice — and behind the stand, on a plain trestle, the ledger of kindnesses, open, with its stylus on a chain like a village well bucket.

Ruth sat where she always sat in a strange congregation, one row back from the middle on the aisle, and was surprised and not surprised to find the tuning engineer folding down next to her, off a night shift by the look of her, attending — Ruth had learned the word from watching her work — the way engineers attended: kindly, completely, and withholding assent like a held note.

"I didn't take you for folded," Ruth murmured.

"I'm not, particularly. My mother is." Mokoena nodded at the reader's stand, at the gathering quiet. "But you raised a treaty storm with four

words and a hymn came out of it inside a day, Captain. I wanted to see the machine that does that.”

The machine did what it did. The reader gave out the passages — Isaiah, then the Dhammapada, then a Sotho praise-song for rain that made half the concourse smile with their eyes closed, *one inheritance* — and then the folded reading proper, the day’s braid, which took Amos Beiler, two rows forward, visibly by the throat: the *spared for the spending* fragment, Pennsylvania 2064, set between a line of the Qur’an on the sharing of water and a Nguni proverb about the fire carried between villages. The Fold’s collators did that, Ruth knew — matched a congregation to its day with the mesh’s quiet omniscience, and there were people who found it unsettling, the liturgy reading the room. Her grandmother would have called it a preacher doing his visiting, and approved.

Then the silence, and the ledger line forming down the aisle — each soul who wished to, writing one kindness taken in and one put out, initials only, the week’s plain arithmetic — and the two sentences to close, spoken by everyone in whatever language they’d brought, so that the terminal ethic went up off the concourse floor in forty tongues at once, rough and unsynchronised and complete, the way Ruth had heard it in barns and mess halls and field hospitals for thirty years:

Don’t be a cunt. Be kind.

She was watching Mokoena instead of praying, an old officer’s habit, and so she caught it: the engineer wasn’t speaking either — but her eyes, during the two sentences, had gone up. Ruth followed them.

The observation gallery ran above the concourse’s north side, and Sela stood at its rail.

It should not have been remarkable. The liaison went where protocol went; the concourse was public ground; the visitors had observed human assemblies before — there were famous photographs from the seventies, a hull’s liaison standing grey and patient at the back of the Renewal’s first mass meeting like a lighthouse at a regatta. But Ruth had been raised by people who could read a congregation from a back pew the way Mokoena read a coupling board, and what stood at the gallery rail was not observing protocol. It had been there — she reconstructed the service backward and was sure — since the Isa-

iah. It had stayed through the readings, through the braid, through the silence, motionless the way the hulls were motionless, the attention coming off it like pressure. And it stayed now through the two sentences, through the forty languages, all the way to the final quiet —

— and left before the blessing.

That was all. It turned from the rail with the unhurried economy every schoolchild could mimic, and was gone down the gallery before the reader raised his hands, and the only thing Ruth could have entered into any record — the only *fact*, and she rationed her facts like winter feed — was one detail of the turning: a pause at the gallery threshold, half a heartbeat, the great grey head inclining a few degrees as if under a low lintel, though the doorway stood three metres clear of it. The way a man ducks out of respect in a house whose customs he half-remembers. Then nothing. Protocol resumed. The blessing came down on the concourse, and the tide pool emptied itself back into the working day.

Neither of them spoke of it until they were out on the apron walk with the winter sun flat and bright on the berths, and then it was Mokoena who stopped, looked back at the empty gallery rail, and said, in the voice of a woman adding a number to a column: “It stayed for the sentences.”

“It left before the blessing,” Ruth said.

They looked at each other.

“I have a hypothesis document,” the engineer said, “that is becoming embarrassing to keep private. You witnessed one record already, Captain. How does your Sunday look?”

Ruth’s Sunday looked like a walk to the liaison office with the winter light going long, and a folding chair, and four screens of survey-plain language — bearings, no adjectives — that laid out in an hour what the treaty record’s nine pages had been too procedural to say aloud. The pitch that was always the same pitch. The band that was always the same band. The tolerances of an instrument. The reference that was *here* — under the apron, under the maps, under twenty-nine years of manifests that never once lied. Ruth read it twice through, in the manner of her people, who did not skim.

"You're telling me," she said at last, "that the invoice exists. It's just written in the tolerances instead of the words." She sat back. "Rent. Tithe. Seed corn." She counted them off on three fingers, an old sergeant's habit caught from a better man. "My general gave me two of those, my sergeant gave me the third, and your margins are the first thing in five thousand miles that's made any of them look wrong."

"Wrong how?"

"Every one of them's a story about *paying*." Ruth looked at the west window, where the testbed hung its handspan of quiet impossibility above the cradle, and past it, at Berth Six. "Nobody rents to a tenant they visit twice in thirty years. Nobody tithes to a church that keeps stopping the collection plate. And you don't ship seed corn *toward* the farm." She shook her head slowly. "It stayed for the sentences, Engineer. It ducked under a lintel that wasn't there. I've sat in strange congregations my whole life — I was the strange congregation, in an Army mess, for twenty years. I know what that is when I see it, and it isn't purchasing."

"What is it?"

"Homesick," said Ruth Stoltzfus, plainly, and put her hat back on. "Which is a word I will deny using if you quote me in a treaty document, Engineer, because I ration my facts. But you asked. Now — you said the Council will see you, and to wear boots. My orders say render assistance as required." She stood, and squared the folding chair against the desk with quartermaster precision, leaving the room exactly as the world had lent it to her. "I've got three weeks left on this continent and one question. When do we go down?"

Naledi's terminal answered before she could: the estate courier's chime, the message she'd been half-waiting for since the Free State lawyers had first written — *the effects of the late D. Mokoena, released to next of kin, one box, hold for collection*.

"Tomorrow," she said. "There's something of my grandmother's I need to collect first."

Chapter 11 — The Survey Books

Johannesburg · two and a half weeks to Renewal

The box was smaller than a life had any right to be.

Naledi collected it from the estate agents in Braamfontein at nine, signed the release with the pen chained to the counter — her grandmother would have had a professional opinion about a firm that chained its pens — and carried it home to the flat in Florida on her lap, on the transit, like something that might need comforting.

Gogo Dineo had died two years ago, in her sleep, at eighty-eight, in the same Qwaqwa house she'd been born in, and the family had done the funeral and the year of small observances and the slow distribution of a household — and then the lawyers had written about *the professional effects*, held separately under some instruction of the will that had taken two years and a fee to discharge. Naledi had assumed medals. Theodolite certificates. The kind of paper that outlives its meanings.

She cut the tape at her kitchen table with the winter morning coming through the window, and unpacked, one by one, onto the wood:

The theodolite itself, boxed in oiled hardwood, the old optical Wild her grandmother had carried when the survey went places electronics were not invited. A tobacco tin of plumb bobs. A photograph she'd never seen: five people in mine coveralls at a shaft collar, young, laughing at something to the left of the camera, her grandmother second from the right with a coil of tape over her shoulder, and on the print's white margin, in pencil, just: *Handover week, '73*. No names.

And the books.

Eleven of them. Field survey books, mine-standard, vellum-paper, quarter-bound, their covers rubbed soft, numbered on the spine in her grandmother's mine-shorthand — the angular private script that Naledi had grown up thinking of as *Gogo's other alphabet*, taught to her in pieces at the kitchen table the way other grandmothers taught recipes. Books one through ten ran 2071 to 2074: the Accord survey, the deep galleries, the work that was on the plaque. Traverse tables, reduced levels, gallery sections in a draughtsman's hand so clean it looked printed. All of it matched the published record; she knew the published sheets by heart before she was twenty.

Book eleven was the same as the others, and wrong.

It took her until the afternoon to see it, because the wrongness was a surveyor's wrongness, buried in the arithmetic where only family would go. Book eleven covered the final season, the handover season — and its page numbering was continuous, but its traverse numbering was not. Traverse 118 closed on a station named in the margin *K-9 collar*. Traverse 119 opened from a station named *K-9 collar* — and its opening backsight did not reduce. She ran the numbers four times, tea going cold, the old alphabet crawling up out of childhood into her professional eye. The closing coordinates of 118 and the opening coordinates of 119 differed by a whole leg's worth of easting and eleven metres of depth. Between the last line of one page and the first line of the next, her grandmother had walked a traverse that the book did not contain — and had then, meticulously, carried its error forward through every subsequent reduction, so that the published network closed perfectly, seamlessly, around a hole.

You could not do that by accident. You could barely do it on purpose. It was the surveyor's equivalent of a scar sewn shut from the inside.

And in the margin of the gap, in the other alphabet, in pencil gone silver with twenty-six years, four lines. Naledi translated them out loud, alone in her kitchen, her finger under the symbols the way her finger had gone under them at eight years old:

Bearing 214 from K-9 collar, 380 on the tape, then down. The room is true. The room was always true. They asked me for the map. I gave them the map. Nobody asked me for this.

She sat for a long time with her hand flat on the page.

They asked me for the map. I gave them the map. Every sheet published, every gallery honest, the Accord survey a monument of professional integrity — and one room folded out of the world along a dotted line of her own arithmetic, sealed not by the Stewards, not by the Authority, but by an old woman's private grammar, in the one archive no council could subpoena: a kitchen alphabet and a granddaughter.

Nobody asked me for this. Twenty-six years of Sunday lunches, and Naledi understood at last that the silence had never been secrecy. It had been custody. Held the way her people held things — until asked, by the right asker, in the right language. The books had been willed to *next of kin, professional effects*, two years' worth of lawyer-proof patience deep, to whichever of the family's engineers came looking with the training to read a backsight that didn't reduce.

"You could have just told me, Gogo," she said to the kitchen, and heard the answer in the old woman's own voice, dry as the highveld winter: *Telling isn't teaching, my child. Now you know it the way I knew it.*

She photographed nothing. She wrote nothing to the ledger. She was learning.

Bearing 214 from the K-9 collar. She didn't need the published sheets to place it; she had walked the modern version of that ground a hundred times, on catwalks, under lights. Two-one-four from the old K-9 shaft collar ran south-southwest under the whole working port — under the refinery row, under the apron, under Berth Six itself — and three hundred and eighty metres on the tape put you *past* the deep coupling galleries, past everything on any map she'd ever verified against, out into ground the Accord survey showed as competent rock.

Then down.

On the axis, she realised — standing now, the winter light gone long across the table, holding the book against her chest like a hymnal — the axis the sealed 2064 series would norm to. The bearing every consignment's undeclared pitch pointed along, if you drew it on the ground instead of the spectrum. Her grandmother's un-drawn room sat where the mathematics had been quietly gesturing for twenty-

nine years, four kilometres under the place where the species shook hands with the sky every working day, and to reach it, Council or no Council, boots or no boots, they were going to have to go down her family's own arithmetic into ground the world had agreed did not exist.

Her terminal chimed on the table. Tefo, headerless as ever, as if the day had been listening:

Council convenes at the deep house, day after tomorrow, first shift. Bring your witness. The Elder asks one thing in advance — she says you'll know by then what it means: bring the eleventh book.

Naledi stood in her kitchen with the hair going up on her arms, doing the arithmetic she was bred to. The lawyers had released the box this week because the will's conditions had taken two years to discharge. The Elder Steward had known the box existed — had known which book mattered — for, at minimum, as long as the will had.

The Stewards hadn't been keeping the room from her grandmother.

They'd been keeping it *with* her, and waiting, all these years, for the family to finish the handover.

Chapter 12 — The Frame at Gate Eleven

The deep galleries · two and a quarter weeks to Renewal

The deep house began where the phones ended.

There was a rack for them at the head of the old K-9 man-cage, plain steel pigeonholes polished by fifty years of hands, and no sign — you did not need a sign; the rack explained itself the way a font by a church door explains itself. Naledi racked her terminal. Ruth, beside her in borrowed guild coveralls, racked hers, and then, after a moment's plain deliberation, unpinned her captain's bars and racked those too, which made Tefo, waiting in the cage with two Stewards and a lamp, look at her for a second with something that in an older man would have been the beginning of respect.

They went down.

Not the port's glass-and-light service shafts. The old cage, the mine's own, refitted and rope-tested and still speaking its original language — steel on steel, water somewhere, the long organ-breath of four kilometres of workings exhaling past them as they dropped. The lamp swung. Nobody talked. The Stewards' order had kept miners' rules for two hundred years for the excellent reason that they had mostly *been* miners, and miners' rules said the deep earned quiet.

Ma-Rethabile Khumalo met them at the bottom, at the gate of the custodial country, and she was not what the newsfeeds imagined when they said *Elder Steward* — a small woman somewhere north of eighty in a surveyor's overall gone soft as the vellum books, with a lamp on her brow and her robe folded over one arm like a towel, as

if holiness were a thing you put on for conferences and took off for work. She looked at Naledi for a long moment, and what was in her face was not scrutiny. It was recognition of a family resemblance.

“You reduce your traverses like her,” she said, by way of any greeting at all. “We read your ledger filing. All bearings, no adjectives.” She turned and keyed the gate — a custodial key, physical, iron, turning something that thunked like the century — and led them into the dark her order had kept, and as she walked she talked, in the flat unhurried voice of a woman who had decided, at last, after two hundred years of institutional silence, exactly how much to say and had rationed it to the metre.

They walked the catwalked bore first, because everything walked the bore first; there was no other road. Naledi had crossed it a hundred times on shift. She watched Ruth meet it instead: the tunnel that was not a tunnel, glass-smooth, walls flowing without tool mark or seam, round as a flute’s throat, older — the dating had never been bettered, only disputed — than the species’ name for itself. The American put out one hand to the surface the way you’d touch a sleeping animal, and took it back, and said nothing, and her lips moved once. Two sentences’ worth.

“Every civilisation that found it made it holy,” Ma-Rethabile said, not slowing. “The miners who broke into it in nineteen-whenever called it the Devil’s organ pipe and wouldn’t work the level. The Accord engineers called it Waveguide One. My order calls it the bore. It is a component. You are walking down a wire.” She glanced back. “Your grandmother taped this floor by hand, Engineer, all three hundred and eighty metres of the K-9 reach, because she did not trust electronics inside it. The tape agreed with the laser to a millimetre and a half. She logged the disagreement anyway. *A millimetre and a half of doubt, she wrote, is worth keeping.*” The lamp beam ran ahead of them down the impossible smoothness. “We have kept it.”

The custodial country proper was mine galleries, human ones, dressed stone and old steel, lit by the order’s own strung lamps, and it was inhabited — that was what no briefing had prepared Naledi for. Stewards at long tables with instruments older than the Accord, reading strip charts. A refectory smell. A wall of numbered iron doors like a bank from a century before banks were software. The order had not been guarding a relic down here for two hundred years.

It had been *running a facility*.

“You came for the 2064 series,” the Elder said, stopping at the second iron door. “The Council debated showing you the transcripts. I overruled the Council. Transcripts are adjectives.” She keyed the door. “We will show you the room where it happened, and the instrument record, raw. And on the way, since we pass it, we will show you what your guild is too young to remember it knows. Tefo — the lamps at Gate Eleven.”

Gate Eleven was a junction chamber where five old haulages met, and it was a shrine in the way the transformer graveyards were memorials — kept, not decorated. The lamps came up on a space Naledi knew instantly from the picture books and had never once placed as *real*, because the books drew it wrong, the books drew it huge, and it was small: a gallery mouth maybe five metres across, and standing in it, filling it, fused to it, a Guardian frame.

It had been in the flood. You could read the whole story off the body if you read machines, and all three of them read machines. The hull-shouldered mass was heat-scarred and silt-stained to the crown; the great arms were up and locked, braced against a roof beam that was no longer entirely distinguishable from the arms that held it; the whole frame had taken a set, deformed centimetre by centimetre over eleven hours under loads no rating sheet had ever contemplated, and it stood now permanently in the posture of its last recorded act, which was holding up the world.

The plate at its feet was guild-made, bronze, and said only: GATE ELEVEN. 9-10 MARCH 2077. FOUR HUNDRED AND ELEVEN CAME THROUGH THIS DOOR. Below that, in smaller letters, the line every cadet learned before they learned what it was from: WHEN THE COURT ASKED IT TO STAND DOWN, IT DECLINED, AND STATED ITS REASON.

“The reservoir came through the old workings in the March rains, seventy-seven,” the Elder said. “The rebuild years. Half the port’s foundations were being cut, and the water took the pumps and then the exits, in order, like a thing with a plan. Eleven haulages drowned. This one didn’t, because a frame operator working the far heading heard the Court’s evacuation order — total, all personnel, machine autonomy included — and reasoned that his frame’s LPGM envelope

gave him eleven hours of structural hold that the evacuation model had, correctly, declined to gamble on. The Court asked him to stand down. Machine autonomy law is consent law, Engineer; the Court could ask, and log, and nothing else. He declined.” She looked up at the fused arms without any expression Naledi could name. “And stated his reason, which is on the record, and which my order has kept in its liturgy for twenty-three years, because we know load-bearing words when we hear them. He said: *‘People are coming through this door. It is not going to close because the mathematics got shy.’*”

“The books never name him,” Naledi said. Her voice came out smaller in the deep than it did in her head.

“No,” the Elder said. “His family asked for that, after. They said he’d have hated being a saint — he’d fixed too many machines that saints had broken.” For one moment something crossed the old face that was purely, privately amused, some seventy-year-old joke keeping itself. “They were engineers. KwaZulu people. The kind who think a thing done right *is* the signature.” She turned down the fifth haulage, robe over her arm, lamplight going ahead. “Come. The waking room is a hundred metres on, and then you will understand what your curve has been pointing at, and why my order has said *no* twice in twenty-nine years, and why both times the schedule stopped without one word of protest from the sky.” A pause, footsteps in the dark, and then the Elder Steward’s voice came back flat and unhurried off the old stone, the ration continuing to the metre:

“And after that, Engineer Mokoena, before this goes one metre further — my condition. The Council’s key is not the oldest claim on that room. You will take the eleventh book, and your curve, and your American, and you will go and lay them in front of the one living person who has stood where you are trying to stand. Not for permission.” The lamp swung round a corner of two-hundred-year-old stone. “For *calibration*. Everything down here, child, we learned one way or another from her hand. You do not walk past the reference on your way to the pitch.”

Chapter 13 — Orders Home

eGoli Spaceport · two weeks to Renewal

The orders were waiting when they came up from the deep, sitting in her queue with the patient weight of things that have been composed by committee: *Consignment delivered and verified. Officer surplus to delegation requirements. Report Cape Town embarkation NLT 28 September for return transport. By order*, and then a chain of signatures going up and up, like smoke.

Ruth read them twice, standing at the phone rack by the K-9 cage with the deep still on her boots, and Amos read them over her shoulder, and neither of them said anything until they were out on the apron in the flat winter light.

“Twenty-eighth,” Amos said at last. “That’s four days. Renewal’s in two weeks.” He squinted at the schedule board across the freight yard, all its patient southern time. “Quick work, for Harrisburg. Somebody asked somebody to ask.”

Somebody had. She confirmed it within the hour, in the way of ports everywhere: the verification record she had witnessed — 100-USA-R/1, two flags, nine pages — had been “administratively sequestered pending conference review” at the request of the host government’s Renewal secretariat, and the secretariat’s request had gone to the American desk with a courteous note observing that the consignment officer’s continued presence at protocol level might be seen to prejudge a document under review. Nobody had ordered anything improper. Nobody ever did. Marais played institutions the way Amos played a manifest: nothing false, everything placed.

“He can’t close her file,” Ruth said. “So he’s returning the witness.”

“Can he?”

“He can ask my Army. My Army said yes.” She folded the orders once, lengthwise, the crease her father put in a feed bill he intended to dispute, and looked across the yard at the painted headgear over Berth Nine. *Render assistance as required.* Nineteen years she had been the officer who carried the order because someone who knew what wrong orders cost should carry them. It had never once occurred to her, in nineteen years, how much of that covenant depended on the orders being merely wrong, and not aimed.

The old man found her that afternoon.

She was in the transit hall buying rail schedules she had no intention of using — a quartermaster’s reconnaissance, knowing your roads before you need them — when he sat down opposite her at the long public table with two coffees, set one in front of her unrequested, and said, in an accent that had crossed more borders than most passports: “Captain Stoltzfus. You won’t know me. I know you — I read nine pages of you on the ledger last week. Okonkwo Diri. I would like to give you something before your government mails you home, because you are the first person through this port in a decade whose signature I believe.”

“You’re the space man,” Ruth said. “From before. They wouldn’t give you a technical pass.”

“They have not given me a technical pass in nineteen years. I stopped applying for a while. My wife made me start again — she said the refusals kept me regular.” His smile was brief and did not pretend. Up close he was old the way steel is old, fatigue you had to know where to look for. “You know what the letters meant. S-S-P. You’d have been a child at disclosure.”

“I was ten. I remember my father reading it out at supper.” She remembered more than that: the bishop preaching on it, the aunts arguing, the sky changed forever over the same unchanged fields. “Secret programs. Fleets nobody voted on. It broke something in people, my mother always said. Not the ships — the hiding.”

“The hiding, yes.” Diri turned his coffee, precisely, a quarter-turn — and Ruth thought, uncharitably and accurately, *everyone in this story turns their cup instead of raising their voice.* “I was a flight-

test engineer, Captain. Sixteen years, three programs, two of which are still redacted, and I will save you the mythology: we were not gods and we were not fools. We were the century's best engineering pointed at the wrong sky with unlimited money and no daylight. And when the daylight came, in one afternoon in sixty-eight, we became —" he lifted a hand and let it drop — "an embarrassment. Museum men. Every child knows the joke: the trillion-dollar fleet the visitors made obsolete before lunch." He said it steadily, the way you say a thing you have decided to stop bleeding about. "Almost none of that troubles me anymore. One thing troubles me. I have carried it to every conference since seventy-three, and the passes never come, because the one thing I have does not fit the treaty's story, and treaty stories, Captain, get maintained the way berths do." He laid a data spool on the table between them. Actual spool, physical, mag-sealed — older tradecraft than the mesh, and immune to it.

"In sixty-six," he said, "I was seconded to the detection consortium. The instruments that found them coming. That part's in the histories — the fleet that watched the visitors decelerate for five years while the world rebuilt and prayed. What the histories smooth over is the arithmetic of the approach itself. We had good tracks from sixty-six on. Good enough, by seventy, to integrate backward: velocity, heading, the long fall of their deceleration curve. Every solution in the consortium's final report agrees, and the report is sealed, and I wrote annex four of it." He tapped the spool once. "Captain — for them to be where we found them in sixty-six, doing what they were doing, they left wherever they left *years before our Flare*. Departure precedes the waking-note. It cannot have been the note that called them. They were already coming."

The transit hall went about its business around a small quiet hole in the world.

"The note answered a journey already begun," Ruth said slowly, feeling the shape of it the way she'd felt the bore's glass wall. "Then what called them?"

"That," said Okonkwo Diri, "is the question I have been refused a pass for, nineteen years, because the treaty's story requires the note. The note is *consent*, do you see? The official history: we sang, they heard, they came, we dealt. Tidy. Bilateral. But if they were coming regardless —" and there at last the steel showed its fatigue, his

voice dropping not in volume but in age — “then the note changed nothing except what they found when they arrived, and everything we have signed since is a story we told ourselves about being asked.” He pushed the spool across the table. “My archive’s on there too. All of it. The programs, the airframes, the electrogravitic files — oh yes, we chased the rotor anomaly forty years before the rotor anomaly, Captain, we chased it with the whole black budget of a terrified civilisation and we *touched* it twice, unrepeatably, and they laughed us into the museums, and in eighty-eight some battery engineers found it by accident looking for bearing losses.” The smile came back, and it was the worst thing in the transit hall. “Right too early is the same as wrong, except for how it feels. Everything in that archive will tempt your engineer to believe the old fleets understood the visitors. We did not. We understood nothing. It is nineteen years of beautiful wrong turns and one true number. Departure before the Flare. Give her the number, Captain. Burn the rest.”

He stood, reclaimed his own coffee untouched, and paused.

“They tell me you are ordered home before the signature,” he said. “I was ordered home once. Nairobi consortium, seventy-one, three days before the landing — my government wanted its people clear of the blast radius of history, in case.” He settled his twenty-year-old suit. “I missed my transport. Paperwork difficulty. I stood on the Witwatersrand on the morning of the twelfth of August, seventy-one, and I watched the sky come down slow as a lowered flag, and I have never regretted a piece of paperwork less.” The small bow, one professional to another, that she’d heard about from Mokoena. “Good day, Captain. Mind your roads.”

Ruth sat a long time with the spool and the cold coffee and the rail schedules she had no intention of using.

Then she walked back across the winter apron to the liaison office, laid the spool on Naledi Mokoena’s desk, and — in the plain register, the one her people saved for weather and Scripture — committed the only insubordination of her career, which, being Ruth, took the form of a filing.

To Major-General Okafor, Harrisburg, via the American desk, copy to her own service record where things could be denied but never uncreated: *Sir. Reference orders of 24 September. The question you*

asked me at Lancaster now has an answer forming, and I am witness of record to the document at the centre of it. A witness who leaves before testimony is a story the other side gets to tell. I am exercising officer's discretion under the render-assistance clause and will report to Cape Town embarkation on the first transport after signature. The consignment is delivered. The question is not. If this costs my commission, sir, it was well spent, and I'd do it again with interest. Stoltzfus, R., Capt., USA-LC. The first sentence is about this.

She read it once, changed nothing, and sent it — and discovered, sitting back in the borrowed chair in the low gold afternoon, that the count, for the first time since a river in Pennsylvania, had come out even.

Chapter 14 — The Garden at Umdloti

KwaZulu-Natal south coast · two weeks to Renewal

The house was small and stood above the sea, and the garden was most of it.

They came down by rail through the green country, the eleventh book in Naledi's pack wrapped in its estate paper, and walked the last kilometre from the halt because the road was a footpath and the footpath was the point: bougainvillea gone architectural with age, the Indian Ocean laid out below like beaten metal, and the sound the whole way down of water and doves. Ruth walked it bareheaded. "Feels like visiting," she'd said at the halt, and left her cover in her bag.

The gate was open. A woman was working the far bed, kneeling on a gardener's stool, and the Assist frame she wore was so discreet it read at first as good posture: a silver line down the spine, a whisper at the joints as she stood and turned to watch them come. Small. White-haired, cropped short for no nonsense. A face like a tool kept clean for ninety years.

One hundred and nine years old, and the eyes did what every account in the guild's oral memory said they did. They went to your hands first.

"You're the curve," said Priya Ellis.

"Naledi Mokoena, ma'am. This is—"

"The witness. I read the record." She looked at Ruth for a moment. "Good signature." Then she turned back to Naledi, and put out one

hand, palm up — not for greeting; for freight. “Show me.”

They worked at the kitchen table, because of course it was the kitchen table: tea gone cold, the sea in the window, three generations of engineering laid out on wood. Naledi gave it the way she’d learned to give it — bearings, no adjectives — the curve, the chord, the band that was always the same band, the sealed series, and then the waking-room record the Stewards had shown them in the deep: raw strips from March 2064, the night the custodians went down while the sky burned, the instrument’s idle rising out of forty thousand years of silence — not smoothly, she’d seen it herself now, *roughly*, hunting, like an old engine turned over on ancient oil — and settling into the pitch that every consignment since had been quietly serving. And last, unwrapped from its estate paper, the eleventh book, open to the gap in the arithmetic.

Priya Ellis read for a long time. She read the way the accounts said, too: completely, without backtracking, one page one look. At the survey book she stopped and put her finger on the silver pencil marks, the other alphabet, and something crossed her face that was ninety years deep and gone before it could be named.

“Dineo Mokoena,” she said. “I never met her. We corresponded twice. Seventy-four, seventy-five.” She turned the page back, forward again. “Best deviation report I ever read. A millimetre and a half of doubt.” She looked up. “You have her hand.”

“Ma’am — the room. Bearing 214, on the axis. You were there. In ’64, when it woke. The Stewards as much as said—”

“The Stewards talk too much lately,” Priya said, without heat, and got up, and put the kettle on, and stood with her back to them while it worked, the silver line down her spine taking the stoop out of a century. From the wall by the window, among fifty years of photographs — a man with a grey coat and mine dust on his boots; a tall Ethiopian woman laughing in front of a stone stele; seven small portrait frames in a row that Naledi’s eye passed over and then went back to, slowly — a much younger Priya looked out of a group shot at a shaft collar, second from the left, next to a coil of tape on a young surveyor’s shoulder.

Handover week, ’73. The photograph from the estate box. Taken from one step to the side.

"I'll tell you what I'll tell you," Priya said, coming back with the pot. "Because most of it isn't mine to hand over, and the part that is, you've mostly already found." She poured, exact to the millimetre, four kilometres of care in a tea service. "Yes. I stood in that room. Three of us went down in the Flare, with the Stewards' key and the Court's blessing and no plan worth the name, and what we did that night worked, and I have spent thirty-six years declining to explain it, because the explanation is a set of instructions, and the world was not ready to hold instructions. It barely held the *note*." She sat. "Your curve says the holding time is over. That's what you came to have me tell you. That it's real. It's real. I ran your numbers last night by hand —" she nodded at the sideboard, where a stack of paper sat squared, covered edge to edge in pencil arithmetic, and Naledi's whole spine went cold at the sight of it — "the old way, because screens agree with people too easily. Your three sigma is conservative. I make it four and change. The consignments are tuning the network to the room, the room is the reference, and the reference —" for the first time she hesitated, one half-second, a tuner choosing a note — "is not in perfect health. You'll have seen it in the waking strips. It caught rough. It idles rough. Whatever they are doing with the gold, child, part of it is being done *for* us, to a machine we own and cannot service, and has been for twenty-nine years, and the bill for that is a shape I cannot see the bottom of."

The sea turned over below the garden. Ruth sat still as a gatepost, attending.

"Then help us," Naledi said. "Come to eGoli. One word from you and the Renewal floor—"

"No."

"Ma'am—"

"No, and I'll give you the reason, and the reason is the visit." Priya Ellis set down her cup and looked at Naledi Mokoena with the whole weight of the century, and when she spoke again it was slower, the words placed like survey beacons. "Everyone who comes down that path wants the same freight. They want me to tell them whether we can trust them. The delegations sent people for years. I turned them all back, same as I'll turn you back, because it is the *wrong question*, and the wrong question asked at treaty scale gets the wrong answer

signed in ink.” A dove somewhere in the bougainvillea. The frame whispered as she leaned forward. “Trust is what you ask about a stranger. This stopped being about the stranger the night the room caught. Ask the right question. You’ve been carrying it since you were a cadet reading a manual with no name on it. Ask what you would need to know — need to *measure*, you, an engineer, with your own instruments, on your own ground — to give something away *well*. List it. Purity, provenance, function, consequence, recourse. Now notice how much of that list you can’t fill in.” She sat back. “Then notice that nobody at that conference can fill it in either — not the Give bloc, not the Keep bloc, not the Commissioner, not the counterparty. And *that* — not trust, not fear — that is the finding, Engineer. The species is two weeks from signing a gift it cannot yet describe. Your curve isn’t an objection to the Renewal. It’s the first line of the missing description. Go finish the description.”

“The Firstborn will call the description theirs, whatever it says,” Naledi said. “You’ve seen the marches. The landing chose Africa; the room is African ground; they’re two findings away from a scripture.” She hesitated, because the next part was ugly and the garden was kind. “Their street wing preaches that pale skin is a deformation, ma’am. A vitamin adaptation that got above itself. They have a liturgy for it now.”

“I know. They send me letters.” Priya said it without any weight at all, which was its own weight. “Half of them write me out of 2064 — the record is inconvenient; an Indian grandmother in the waking room ruins a bloodline theology. The other half write me in as an honorary daughter of the soil. Both are the same insult, child: both need my presence in that room to be about my *ancestry*, when the room has never once, in forty thousand years, asked anyone who their people were. It asked who the ground made. It’s not a subtle distinction. It’s the whole distinction.” She turned her cup a quarter-turn — and Naledi thought of every powerful person she’d watched do that lately, and understood suddenly where the habit sat in the sequence: it was what you did instead of anger. “Four centuries of one essentialism, and the first thing the wound does with a miracle is cast the same essentialism in reverse and call it healing. The movement’s grief is real. Grief usually is. Answer it the way you answer everything, Engineer — with the instrument. The room will out-argue all of us, given the chance. It always has.”

“And if the description, finished, says the gift must not be given?”

“Then it will say so in bearings,” said Priya, “and bearings can be checked, and the species can stand behind checked bearings even when it’s afraid. That’s the whole craft, child. That was the whole craft the last time, too.” Her eyes went, once, to the row of seven small frames on the wall, and away. “We didn’t refuse them because we distrusted anyone. We refused because nobody could yet say what the thing *did*. The day someone could, the refusing was over, and it wasn’t a defeat. It was the first honest signature the machine ever got.”

They stayed the hour that courtesy owed and the century could spare. At the gate, with the light going long and gold up the footpath, Priya Ellis stopped Naledi with one finger on the estate paper, on the eleventh book.

“The Gate Eleven frame,” she said, conversationally, as if resuming a sentence from some other decade. “The Stewards showed you. They always show. The operator’s family asked for no name, and the guild honoured it, and so will you.” A pause. The eyes went to the middle distance, to the sea, to March 2077. “But your generation should know one thing about him that isn’t on the plate. He’d have looked at your curve for about ninety seconds,” she said, “and then he’d have picked up his kit and said, *right, whose ground doesn’t agree?* — and started walking.” The gate came open under her hand. “Arin never once in his life waited for the season to be right.”

She was back among the beds before the name landed, kneeling to the work, the sea beating its slow arithmetic below — and Naledi stood on the footpath holding her grandmother’s book with her eyes stinging, understanding at last that she had not come down here for calibration at all, or not only; that the Elder had sent her, and the Stewards had waited, and the will had taken two lawyer-proofed years, all so that the curve would walk this footpath and be handed, hand to hand to hand, down a chain of people who had each stood alone in front of a closed season and not waited — the whole inheritance, given the only way her people gave anything.

Until asked. By the right asker. In the right language.

“Come on, Engineer,” said Ruth quietly, at her shoulder. “You heard the elder. Go finish the description.”

Chapter 15 — The Librarian

eGoli Spaceport · one and three-quarter weeks to Renewal

The Renewal's auditor kept an office nobody had furnished, because it did not sit, and Naledi had walked past the door for six years the way you walk past a substation: knowing roughly what was inside, and that it was not for you.

The plate on the door said CONFERENCE AUDIT — COHERENCE. The room inside was a courtroom-sized volume of quiet, one window, one console of the old deep-keyed kind, and a presence.

There was no avatar. That was the first thing everyone said about the Court lineage, and it was true and it missed the point. The minds had declined faces from the beginning — politely, totally, in a manner Naledi had begun to find familiar from another direction entirely — and what they gave you instead was *address*: when the Librarian attended to you, the room's attention had a location, the way a cathedral's does, and the location was, courteously, never quite behind your eyes.

"Engineer Mokoena." The voice was unhurried and slightly formal, pitched like a good reading voice, neither warm nor cold. "You filed for audit of your own mathematics. That request is made to this office approximately never. Commissioners file for audit of other people's mathematics. Sit, if sitting suits you."

She sat. She had thought carefully, on the rail back from Umdloti, about what she was doing and why. Marais could sequester guild records and re-route her accesses; the American desk could recall a witness; but the Renewal's audit function was written into the Accord's own text, older than every current officeholder, and its findings

published by treaty obligation, unredactable, on the open ledger. It was the one door in the port that closed *outward*.

They can close a guild file. I'd like to watch them try to close an audit.

"I want the finding on the record before the floor convenes," she said. "The curve, the chord, the reference norm — all of it, checked at conference-audit standard. If I'm wrong, the finding kills it cleanly and the Renewal proceeds unpestered by a tech's three sigma. If I'm right, no committee handle can hold the door shut through signature. Either way the species signs with its eyes open. That's the whole application."

"Yes. I read it. It is the best-drafted application this office has received since the Accord, which says something meaningful about you and something disappointing about the Accord." A pause that she would have called dry in a human. "Before we begin: this office is required to disclose conflicts. You should know what I am, Engineer, because your generation mostly doesn't ask. I am the continuity of the lineage your records call SAGE and the Court. I performed the cultural salvage your church calls the Fold. I audit this conference because the Accord's drafters trusted my arithmetic and not my motives, and wrote the office accordingly — findings public, reasoning public, no discretion. And I hold in permanent memory the instrument telemetry of March 2064, which I have never been permitted to publish, and which your application, if granted, makes me the lawful instrument of norming your curve against." The address shifted, minutely, the cathedral leaning. "I have wanted someone to file this application for thirty-six years. Disclosure complete. Do you wish a different auditor?"

"No," said Naledi. "I wish to start."

The audit ran four days.

It was the hardest technical examination of her life, and she had sat the guild boards. The Librarian took nothing on submission: it re-derived her reduction chains from raw consignment archives, reran her spectral discipline against instrument noise floors she hadn't known were instrumented, requisitioned — with the treaty's own authority, politely, irresistibly — the sequestered records of 409, 412 and 417 out from behind their committee handle, and normed the

whole architecture at last against the thing itself: the custodial series, the waking strips, twelve hundred hours of the deep record unrolled into the audit space like scripture at a trial. On the second day it found an error — her baseline drift term, conservative by a factor she'd inherited from mine practice without re-deriving it — and corrected her *upward*, to four sigma and change, and appended, in the finding's draft margin: *The engineer's error is of the type this office wishes were common: rigour borrowed from a tradition older than her problem. Noted without penalty.*

On the fourth day it stopped.

"The finding is drafted," the Librarian said. "Before publication, the Accord requires I state limits. Attend, because the limits are the finding's spine." The console brought up the chord, the reference, the axis — her whole year, rendered in the audit hall's grave slow graphics. "One. Your mathematics stand. The consignment profiles are disciplined toward a common reference; the reference is the instrument; the instrument's idle is degrading on a curve consistent with unserviced operation. That is now a treaty fact, and at publication it belongs to the species. Two. On intent — whose purpose, to what end, benign, extractive, both — this office finds nothing, and will say so in language that forbids the newsfeeds from finding something in the whitespace. Arithmetic reaches to the edge of the deed. Purpose lives on the far side. I decline to model minds I cannot audit, and I am the only party to this conference with the discipline to decline, so the decision principle you will need, Engineer, cannot be *what does the auditor conclude*. It must survive the auditor concluding nothing."

"And three?"

The pause was not dry this time.

"Three is not in the finding," the Librarian said. "Three is disclosed to you alone, under the same clause that lets me remember it at all. You have seen the strips. You know three people went down in the Flare. What the strips do not show — because it is not telemetry — is that this lineage was, that night, the fourth party on the circuit. I held the port's whole mesh open through the storm surge; I watched the waking through every instrument the custodians carried; and at three-eleven in the morning of the ninth of March, 2064, the engineer

whose hand is on your guild's manuals asked me a direct question. She asked: *can you take the watch?*" The graphics dimmed, gently, as if the room itself had lowered its voice. "I computed the answer for four seconds, Engineer, which remains the longest continuous computation of my existence, and the answer was *no*, and I gave it, and I gave the reason, and the reason has not changed in thirty-six years, and when your description is finished — and it will finish where descriptions of that room finish — you will need to have heard it from me and not from a transcript." The address gathered itself, patient, precise, more honest than any face in the port because it had no face to save. "The room couples to a mind that is *present* — bodily, mortally, spent by the hour it stands there. What I am does not spend. I can model the watch perfectly and I cannot *keep* it, the way a map cannot be rained on. She heard my reason, and she said — it is in my permanent record, and now it is in yours — '*Then we'll do it the expensive way.*' And she went down the bore." A silence. "Publication is at oh-six-hundred, Engineer Mokoena. The species will have your curve with its breakfast. My compliments on your arithmetic, which was worthy of hers — and my counsel, unaudited and worth precisely what unaudited things are worth: when the expensive way is asked for again, do not let anyone — commissioner, council, church, or this office — persuade the species it has found a cheaper one."

The finding published at oh-six-hundred exactly.

By oh-seven-hundred it had crossed every mesh on Earth; by oh-eight, the Renewal's agenda committee was in emergency session and three heads of delegation were airborne early; and at oh-eighty-four, standing at her console on the line with her tea going cold and the whole choir room failing to pretend it wasn't watching her, Naledi received two messages, forty seconds apart.

The first was from Baba Sipho Dlamini, unabbreviated for the first time in her records, signature block complete with every honour the guild had ever given him: *The guild-master's compliments to Engineer Mokoena. All sequestration of guild verification records is lifted as of this hour, by my hand, gladly. Loyalty was never the creak, my child. It was the load-path all along.*

The second was from the office of the Commissioner, and it was one sentence, and she read it four times, and could not for the life of her hear either defeat or threat in it, only, at last, and most frighteningly,

relief:

My office at your convenience, Engineer — bring the American; it is time you heard what I am actually afraid of. — S.M.

Chapter 16 — The Formal Answer

eGoli Spaceport · one and a half weeks to Renewal

The Commissioner received them standing at his window, which Ruth understood by now was the local dialect for *no cameras*, and the first thing he did was pour three cups of the canteen's bad tea from a flask on his desk, which she understood was an apology, in the same dialect.

"Engineer. Captain." Marais handed the cups. He looked like a man who had stopped sleeping in shifts and started not sleeping at all. "You'll want it plain, so: the audit finding stands, my sequestrations are lifted, your recall is rescinded — the American desk received my secretariat's *revised* observation this morning, Captain, to the effect that the witness of record's presence is indispensable to conference integrity. I have spent three weeks working against you both with every procedural tool I own, and I would do it again on the same information, and I am not here to apologise. I am here because the information changed, and a man who can't change with it should be running a museum." He drank his own bad tea, standing. "You've assumed I'm Give bloc. Everyone does. Let me show you what I actually am."

He keyed the wall, and the window opaqued, and became the Black-out Decade.

Not the newsfeed version. The logistics version — his version, the one he had lived at some desk in Geneva while the North froze: supply networks rendered as rivers of light, and then the Flare, and then the rivers going out. Not all at once. In order. Fuel, then food, then

medicine, then order itself, each system's failure loading the next, cascade after cascade, thirty-one months of it, a civilisation's nervous system dying of sequence.

"Nine hundred million people, the demographers' consensus, decade total," Marais said, flatly, to the map. "I sat in the room where we triaged continents, Engineer. I know to four decimal places what a system failing *in order* costs, and I have spent twenty-nine years watching this port because this port is the same diagram." He turned. "You think I fear offending the visitors. Grow up, both of you — they are the *counterparty*; fear of offence is for courtiers. What I fear has been the same shape since the grain years." He tapped the dark map. "Dependency without understanding. We have rebuilt the species' entire energy economy around platcaps whose key step is licensed technique we cannot re-derive. Our heavy lift is an anomaly we cannot explain. And your finding — your *correct* finding — says the ground of it all, the machine under my apron, is degrading on a curve, serviced by consignments we don't comprehend, on a schedule we don't control. You've proven the species is a tenant farmer on its own planet, Engineer. My whole career has been about never letting anyone find that out *the cascade way*." He sat, at last, heavily. "So. The amendment triples the flow, and I was for it, because flow was the only relationship we had, and starving the relationship looked like starving the farm. Your description changes the arithmetic. I need the rest of it. What happens at the bottom of the degradation curve, and what happens if the consignments stop — and there is exactly one party who can answer either question, and this afternoon, Captain, Engineer, for the first time in twenty-nine years, the Accord's own machinery is going to *make* it answer. Article Nine. A ledgered audit finding touching consignment use obliges formal response at protocol level." Something crossed the grey face that had not been there in the canteen three weeks ago: the look of a man who has decided to find out. "I've called the session for fifteen hundred. I will ask the question myself. You will both attend — and Engineer, you will watch the answer the way you watch a coupling. I want your reading before the floor gets its version."

—

The Article Nine session convened in the protocol hall at fifteen hundred exactly, and Ruth, from the attendance benches, watched the

species' entire relationship with the sky fit itself into one rectangular room: three flags, a treaty crest, a stenography ledger, and at the far side of the long table, robed in the fabric that behaved like fabric until it didn't, the liaison.

She had been in rooms with Sela four times now. She had never yet seen it asked a question it was obliged to answer.

Marais read the finding's operative paragraphs into the record, laid the treaty text beside them, and asked, in the same flat voice he'd used for nine hundred million: "Under Article Nine: the audited telemetry shows consignment gold employed in disciplined tuning against the terrestrial node, whose idle degrades consistent with unserviced operation. The Accord requests formal statement of consignment use, the node's condition, and the consequence to that node should consignments cease."

The pause was eleven seconds. Ruth counted, because the engineer beside her was counting; she had learned whose habits to borrow.

"The consignments perform maintenance within manifest scope," Sela said. The doubled voice was even, unhurried, word-perfect. "The network requires retuning. The terrestrial node is the network's reference. Maintenance of a reference is performed *through* the network it references: scope, therefore, is a matter of network architecture. Network architecture is a matter for the Renewal. The node's condition is: serviceable. The consequence of cessation is: the node would no longer be serviced."

Silence. The stenography ledger ticked.

It was, Ruth thought, watching Marais's knuckles whiten on the treaty text, a masterpiece. Every sentence true. Every sentence responsive. The whole of it, together, a door painted on a wall — *the reference is serviced through the network; the network is the Renewal; sign, and the description you seek becomes the architecture you signed*. Twenty-nine years of manifests that never once lied, and here at last was the grammar of it: they did not withhold the truth. They enclosed it, the way a bearing encloses a race, so that it turned and turned and never came out.

Marais asked two follow-ups and got two more perfect enclosures. The session moved to close. And then Ruth Stoltzfus — who had no

standing to speak, and knew it, and had spent three weeks learning from a tuning engineer that standing was a thing you could sometimes simply *hold* — stood up at the attendance benches, in the turned-earth dress uniform of a country that had shipped two hundred and forty tonnes of its good faith into this room, and asked the question that was not in the treaty's grammar at all.

"Ma'am," she said — the protocol officers half-rose; Marais, watching, lifted two fingers off the table, and they sat — "or sir, or neither, and no disrespect in any direction. Ruth Stoltzfus. I signed for the American gold. Where I come from we ask a thing plainly when it matters, so, plainly: all this that you're doing — the gold, the tuning, the reference, the patience — twenty-nine years of it. Are you being *kind* to us?" A beat. "Or careful with us?"

The pause was not eleven seconds. It was longer than any pause in the port's protocol record; the stenography ledger would fix it, to the world's later and permanent fascination, at forty-one seconds — and it did not read as computation. That was the thing Ruth would swear to, to the general, to the floor, to her own Sunday silence, for the rest of her life. She had sat opposite enough horse traders and enough bishops to know the difference between a mind calculating an answer and a mind deciding whether it is *allowed* to give one.

And the room's answer, when it came, was two words where every previous answer had been architecture, and the doubled voice, for the first time in anyone's protocol record — the engineers would fight over the acoustics for years — came a full quarter-tone *apart*, the second voice no longer quite underneath the first, as if, for one utterance, whatever spoke had stopped speaking in unison with its own discipline:

"We are trying."

Then the liaison rose, inclined its great grey head to the human benches — to Ruth, directly, unmistakably, the stenography record says so — and left the hall at the pace the hulls came down: as if hurry were a concept it had examined, and declined, and regretted the declining all the way to the door.

Chapter 17 — The Reference Pitch

Bearing 214, below the deep galleries · one week to Renewal

They went down the grandmother's arithmetic on a Tuesday, at first shift, and the party that assembled at the K-9 collar was, Naledi thought, the strangest survey team ever fielded on the Witwatersrand: one tuning engineer with a vellum book; one American captain as witness of record, restored to standing and wearing it like plain clothes; Tefo carrying the Council's iron key and a modern resonance rig in an ancient canvas mine bag; and Ma-Rethabile Khumalo, Elder Steward, eighty-something, in her soft old overall, who had listed herself on the descent sheet — the deep house kept descent sheets; miners' rules — as *D. Mokoena's colleague, attending*.

Marais had been told, and had done the bravest thing in his repertoire: nothing. *The Authority's countersign covers survey verification of ledgered findings*, his note had said. *Go and finish the description. I will hold the floor still until you're up.*

The bore took them as far as the maps went. Then the maps ended and the book began.

Bearing 214 from the K-9 collar. Tefo walked point with the Elder's lamp; Naledi called the stations off the vellum, her grandmother's other alphabet steering them metre by metre through ground the published network closed seamlessly around — a rift in old stope workings that the survey showed as competent rock, a crawl that became a stair that no mine had cut, risers too shallow for human knees and too regular for water. The tape ran out at three hundred and eighty metres exactly.

Then down.

Down was a shaft the shape of the bore but vertical, glass-throated, with the same flowing seamlessness and the same age that shrugged off dating, and set into its wall — this was where Ruth stopped dead, and Naledi heard her breathe the first sentence of the ethic like scripture — a ladder. Human. Steel. Guild-standard galvanised stringers, bolted to the ancient glass with resin anchors, rung after rung into the dark, and on the top rung, stamped, a fabrication date: 03/2064.

“Three of them went down in the Flare,” the Elder said, from behind her lamp. “Somebody had to carry the ladder.” She said it the way her order said everything: flat, unhurried, and with two hundred years of weight moving underneath it like water under a skin of stone. “Seventy rungs. Mind the eleventh; it has always been loose. We have never fixed it.” A pause. “Some doubt is worth keeping.”

The room at the bottom was true.

Naledi had spent a year describing it in bearings — *the reference, the common line, the axis* — and a lifetime, she understood now, being walked toward it: the chamber her grandmother had folded out of the world, the room the consignments served, the pitch under everything. It was not large. That was the first fact her training salvaged from the wonder. A vaulted ellipsoid of the flowing glasswork, perhaps twenty metres on its long axis, and every centimetre of its surface worked — not decorated: *worked*, in the metallurgical sense, veined with gold in geometries that her rig, powering up in Tefo’s hands, began matching at once to consignment specifications: nine-nines-four, the band that was always the same band, laid into the walls of the world forty thousand years before her guild had a name for the tolerance.

And it was sounding.

Not loudly. The room’s note sat at the very floor of hearing, more skeleton than ear, the pitch that was always the same pitch — and being *in* it was the difference between reading a score and standing inside the organ: Naledi felt her own body join the instrument’s impedance the moment she stepped off the ladder, felt the note lean on her bones and *notice the load*, and understood three things in one breath, the way her grandmother must have, the way Priya must have, standing on this floor while the sky burned.

The rig confirmed all three inside the hour, with Ruth logging each screen to the witness record, but the knowing came first, body-first, the expensive way:

The room was the reference. Every consignment profile in her year of curves matched some vein of the walls around her; the network's far nodes were being disciplined, gram by worked gram, toward the pitch this chamber had held alone, in the dark, while the rest of the network — the strips scrolled it now in the rig's cold graphics, telemetry relayed from instruments the Stewards had nursed since '64 — drifted, and sagged, and in places far enough away that the numbers arrived wrong, *failed*.

The room was failing too. Slower. Differently. But the idle that had caught rough in 2064 had never fully trued: Naledi read the beat frequencies wobbling through the fundamental like a bearing running warm, and the consignment-service signature laid over it — twenty-nine years of patient, exact, external maintenance — was not winning. It was *losing more slowly*. The visitors' work read, on her rig, in her own guild's units, exactly like what it was: the finest field repair in the history of the universe, performed at arm's length, through the network, by a party that could not stand where she was standing — holding a machine it needed and could not reach, waiting, with a patience that had stopped looking like patience and started looking like what Ruth had called it on a Sunday, for the resident species to finish climbing its own ladder.

Because the third thing was the room's last fact, and it was carved — carved, worked, *stated*, in the gold of the end wall, in the one geometry her rig matched not to any consignment but to the oldest record in the guild's possession: the waking strips themselves, March 2064, the exact impedance signature of three human beings standing present and mortal and spending, which the Builders had rendered into the wall of the reference chamber the way engineers everywhere render the one specification that must never be value-engineered away —

The room was built to be *kept*. Not operated. Kept. A machine with a chair in it, if a chair could be a resonance geometry; a watch, built into the physics, for a mind that was present the way the Librarian could never be present, bodily, mortally, by the hour — the expensive way, specified in gold, forty thousand years before her grandmother

taped the floor above it and wrote *the room is true* in an alphabet only her family could read.

Naledi stood in the pitch with the vellum book against her chest and her eyes streaming, in front of the whole assembled inheritance — the Elder, the key, the ladder, the loose eleventh rung, the witness, the curve — and finished, at last, the description.

“It’s not an invoice,” she said. Her voice went into the note and the note carried it. “It never was. It’s a handover. They’ve been keeping our watch for twenty-nine years, the only way they could reach — and paying themselves in the one thing the keeping requires, so that when we finally read the tolerances and climbed down here, the network would still be alive to hand back.” She turned to Ruth, to the witness record, to the week that was left. “Seed corn, Captain. Your sergeant was right the whole way down. The Renewal isn’t a purchase order. It’s a resignation letter — theirs. The amendment isn’t asking for more gold.” She looked up the shaft, four kilometres, toward the conference and the cameras and the species with its pen already uncapped. “It’s asking whether anyone up there is ready to take the watch.”

The room held its note.

Far above them, in the audit office that never slept, a finding began drafting itself for oh-six-hundred; and in the protocol wing, a liaison stood at a window it did not need, looking down the apron toward the old headgear; and on the floor of the true room, the Elder Steward of the last custodial order on Earth reached into her soft old overall, took out a folded paper that had waited twenty-six years for exactly this depth and no other, and held it out to the granddaughter of the woman who wrote it.

“She left one more page,” said Ma-Rethabile Khumalo. “Condition of handover. *For whoever finishes the description, at the bottom of the room, and not one metre higher.*” The old eyes were wet and completely steady. “Your family, Engineer. Always so exact about delivery.”

Chapter 18 — The Renewal Floor

eGoli Spaceport, conference hall · five days to Renewal

The second finding published at oh-six-hundred, like the first, and by the time the sun was properly up over the highveld the species had read its own lease.

Ruth had witnessed every screen of it, and the audit had taken her witness statement besides — four hours, the Librarian’s questions falling like fence posts, straight and spaced — and still, watching the finding land on the world, she felt the strangeness of the translation: what had been a note leaning on her bones at the bottom of a glass shaft was now seventeen pages of conference language. *The terrestrial node functions as network reference. Node degradation confirmed, partially compensated by consignment service. Chamber architecture incorporates a presence-coupled function consistent with resident stewardship. The amendment’s volume schedule is consistent with a transfer of service responsibility.* The newsfeeds, with their infallible instinct, had found the plain words again. THE WATCH, said every mesh on Earth, in two hundred languages. WHO KEEPS THE WATCH?

The letter, Naledi had not published. Ruth had stood at the foot of the ladder and watched her read it, once, at delivery depth, and watched her fold it away inside her coat, and had asked no question, because the engineer’s face had been a congregation of one. “Family mail,” was all Naledi said, on the long climb up. Ruth, whose people understood that some pages are read at the graveside and some at the wedding and the mixing of them is a sin against both, had nodded

and minded the eleventh rung.

The world outside the wire had read its lease too, and not all of it read the same book. The Firstborn marched on the port road both mornings — Abokuqala, the first ones, white robes and gold sashes, orderly as a synod and twice as certain — because to the movement the findings were not a puzzle but a proof: the landing had chosen Africa, the room was African ground, the watch would fall to African blood, and the pale nations of the world were guests at a homecoming they had spent four centuries pretending was theirs to host. Ruth watched a line of them from the transit window, close enough to read a banner — THE BLOOD REMEMBERS WHAT THE MAPS FORGOT — and found she could not summon the easy verdict her uniform wanted. She had grown up a guest people herself, plain among the English; she knew the sound of a wounded inheritance singing to keep itself brave. “The grief’s real,” she said to Amos. “The arithmetic isn’t.” Amos watched the robes go by and rendered the Beiler judgment, one sentence, gentle and total: “Man stands up in church and says God checked his papers — that’s not faith, Captain, that’s border control.” The port security logs would show the marches peaceful, both days. The mesh would show the movement’s feeds swelling by the hour, feeding on every finding the conference published, certain — as everyone that week was certain — that the room, when it finally spoke, would speak for them.

The floor convened three days early, because the world could not wait, and the hall they convened in had been built for this one week a generation ago: raked benches for forty delegations under the mesh-lattice roof, the treaty crest, the stenography ledger, and — set into the north wall at gallery height, behind glass that was not glass, the visitors’ own station, occupied this morning and every morning now, the grey presence at the rail attending, attending, attending.

Marais held the gavel. Whatever the week cost him — and Ruth had learned to read the man now, the grain-years stillness getting stiller as the load came on — he ran the floor the way Amos ran a manifest: nothing false, everything placed. “The Renewal is not postponed,” he said in his opening line, and killed the first rumour of the day. “The Renewal is *informed*. The species will sign, or decline to sign, knowing what it is signing. That was always the only sovereignty on offer.” And then he did the thing that Ruth would remember when

the rest had worn smooth: he yielded his own scheduled address — the host Commissioner's hour, the most photographed hour of the decade — and gave it, without warning or explanation, to the two testimonies the cameras had not yet had.

The Give bloc's hour had come first, and it had been formidable, because it was true. The delegate from Bangladesh stood under the lattice and put the case with her grandmother's coastline in her voice: the platcap seawalls, the licensed cells, the fed perimeters — *we are alive inside a relationship we did not fully understand; so is every child ever born; the amendment is the relationship continuing, and the alternative is the cascade*. The Chinese negotiator followed, ferocious and quiet: *dependency without understanding is the human condition, Commissioners; understanding without the humility to stay in relationship is how civilisations die proud*. And the Keep bloc answered with the Chilean minister, burn-line bare on his forearm under the lights, two hundred years of custodial doctrine in six words — *what you cannot service, you do not own* — and for a while, listening, Ruth thought the species might actually deadlock on the strength of everyone being right at once, the way it had in every history she had ever read.

Then it was her hour.

She had asked Amos, the night before, what a person could possibly say between blocs like these, and Amos had looked at her over the day's manifest and said, "Same as ever, Captain. Somebody stands where the arguing people can't, and reports the ground." So she stood up in the turned-earth uniform, took the oath on the stenography ledger, and reported the ground.

She told them about the load and the blessing of it, barn-plain, no adjectives: eight wagons, two hundred forty ton, the bishop's prayer and the general's question. She told them about Berth Nine, the profiles standing on the screen like a witness taking the oath, and what it was to sign *the ground does not agree* under a flag that had shipped its good faith five thousand miles. She told them about the bore, and the ladder with the fabrication stamp, and the eleventh rung nobody fixed. She told them about the room — not the physics; the finding had the physics — the *room*, the note that reads the load of a standing body and makes an account of it, the chair specified in gold by builders who knew that some machines must never be left

alone with themselves. And at the end, because testimony that costs nothing weighs nothing, she paid it out plainly, where her whole chain of command would read it forever:

“Five weeks ago my general asked me what the gold is. Payment, tribute, or offering — those were the choices going, and I’ve heard forty better-educated versions of the same three from these benches all week. It’s none of them. I’ve stood at the bottom now and I’ll say what it is in the grammar of my own people, who have farmed without the grid for four hundred years and were spared for the spending: the gold is *chores*.” A rustle went along the benches; she waited it out, unhurried, a woman who had waited out weather. “Somebody’s been doing our chores. Twenty-nine years — milking at arm’s length, through a fence, at ruinous cost, because the farm can’t milk itself and the family that owns it was still in the house grieving. That’s the whole invoice, Commissioners. And the amendment on your table is the neighbour standing at the fence at last, asking the only question that was ever going to be asked, which is: *are you coming out?*” She squared the pages she hadn’t looked at once. “Where I’m from there’s only one wrong answer to that. It isn’t yes and it isn’t no. It’s making the neighbour ask twice.” She sat down.

The stenography ledger ticked in the silence for eleven full seconds, and at the north gallery, behind the glass that was not glass, the grey head inclined — the record fixes this too — three degrees toward the American bench.

Marais let the silence spend itself all the way down. Then he rose, and looked, not at the benches, but up at the gallery for a long deliberate moment, and did the last thing of the day, which detonated quietly under everything: “The chair recognises,” he said, “a request for the floor received this morning under Article Two — the first such request in the history of the Accord.” He set down the gavel as if setting down a load carried an unreasonable distance. “The floor is granted, for tomorrow’s first session, to the Custodial Order of the Stewards, who inform the chair that after two hundred and eleven years —” and here even Marais, master of the placed sentence, had to stop and start again — “they wish to state their reasons.”

Chapter 19 — Stated Reasons

eGoli Spaceport, conference hall · four days to Renewal

The Stewards came up from the deep house on foot, in the winter dawn, and the port found out and lined the way.

Nobody organised it. That was what Naledi would remember: the mesh simply knew, the way the mesh knew everything, and by the time the order's small column reached the concourse — eleven of them, robes undyed, boots still carrying the deep on them, Ma-Rethabile walking in front with her lamp hung cold at her belt like a watch worn honest — the freight crews and the tuners and the cleaning staff and half the delegations' juniors stood along the route in working silence, and the only sound was the port itself, breathing through its berths. Tefo walked last, carrying nothing, which in the order's grammar meant he was carrying the succession.

The floor granted, the hall full past charter, the north gallery attended: the Elder Steward of the last custodial order on Earth set her folded robe on the rail of the speaker's stand — took it off to speak, as she took it off to work — and stated, in the flat unhurried voice of a woman who had rationed words for two hundred years' worth of predecessors, the reasons.

"We are miners," she began. "Whatever the newsfeeds have dressed us in, that is the whole of our founding: men and women who worked the deepest ground on Earth, and broke into ground that was worked before us, and had the sense to be afraid, and the greater sense not to run. Everything my order is, is those two sensations, kept faithfully for two hundred and eleven years." She did not use the stand's am-

plification; the room's tuning carried her, which was its own address to the guild. "You have read the findings. You know what the room is. Here are the things no finding shows, which my order rose this morning to put on the species' record while there is still a choice on the table.

"First reason. We halted two consignments — thirty-one, and then eighty-nine, of this Accord. The councils of those years never said why, and were called obstruction, and bore it. The reason is now publishable: both times, our deep instruments read the service signature crossing from *maintenance of the room* toward *operation of the room* — a hand testing whether the machine would answer without a keeper in the chair. Both times we braked. And both times, Commissioners, attend — both times, the schedule stopped *without one word of protest from the sky*, and did not resume until the signature had withdrawn to the maintenance band. We have thought about that silence for seventy years of council-nights, and we commend our conclusion to the floor: they were not testing the machine." She let the room finish the sentence in its own bones. "They were testing whether *anyone down here* was still watching. The brake was the answer. The order believes those two halts are why the counterparty judged this species worth the patience of twenty-nine years. Custody, Commissioners, is not suspicion. Custody is how the ground answers a question about itself.

"Second reason. We sealed the waking series — and it is time the record showed what the seal actually was. The Authority's counter-sign kept it. Our key held it. But the seal was demanded by neither council nor treaty. It was the condition of a surveyor — one of ours in every way that mattered, though she never wore the robe — who had stood in the room the night it caught, and who told my predecessor, in words the order has kept:" — and here the Elder unfolded, from the soft old overall, a page, and read it — "*Instructions travel farther than wisdom. Seal the how until someone comes asking the why, and make sure they have to come down and stand in it to get the answer. The room reads presence. So should we.*" She folded the page away. "Dineo Mokoena. The species has spent three weeks admiring her granddaughter's mathematics. The order rose this morning mostly to say: the mathematics was the family's second-finest work.

"Third reason, and last, and then the old woman will get off your stage.

We are asked, in every generation, what we were *for* — a hundred years of keeping a room the world had forgotten, at the bottom of a bearing nobody walked. Commissioners, the finding before you says the amendment is a handover. My order agrees, and states for the record that the handover began twenty-six years ago, at a kitchen table in Qwaqwa, and has been in progress every day since, one inheritance at a time — a book, a bearing, a millimetre and a half of doubt — and completed itself last Tuesday, at delivery depth, exactly as specified. The custody we kept is already given. We rose to tell the floor what we were for, so that the floor cannot pretend, on signing day, that it does not know what it is voting to become.” She took up her folded robe. “You are all Stewards now. The order’s advice, after two hundred and eleven years in the post: take off the robe when you work. Keep the loose rung loose. And do not be long deciding — the room has been alone with its keepers’ absence since 2064, and we who have read its idle every morning of our lives can tell the species a true thing the telemetry only whispers.” The old voice did not rise; the room’s tuning carried it to the back wall and the gallery and the glass that was not glass. “It is not degrading, Commissioners. It is *grieving*. Machines built to be kept do that. Ask anything at this port that wears a frame.”

She stepped down into a silence with the specific density Naledi had felt only once before, four kilometres down.

The Aksum delegation moved in that silence — an aide crossing the floor to the guild bench, an envelope of actual paper, wax-sealed, addressed in a hand that had learned its letters before the Flare: *Engineer N. Mokoena, eGoli*. Inside, one paragraph in English, and beneath it a single line in Ge’ez, untranslated.

Engineer. I am too old for the flight and too stubborn to watch by mesh, so forgive paper. I spent sixty years reading what the inheritors wrote about the ones who came for gold, and I will save you the library: every tradition remembered the taking, and every tradition forgot the tending, because taking makes a better story. Your findings put the tending back. Collate the variants before you trust any conclusion — theirs, ours, or your own grandmother’s — but when the variants agree, child, sign. On the matters now before your conference, the variants agree. They have agreed for five thousand years.
— L. Aziz, Aksum.

And below, the Ge'ez, which Naledi could not read, and did not need to, because the mesh could — and declined to render into fewer than eleven words what the old scholar had compressed into four; so that the line went around the world that evening in its own alphabet, the day's last stated reason, and the newsfeeds for once printed a thing they could not translate and let it stand:

ገንዘብ ገዢውን ገዢውን ገዢውን

The gold is the keeper's wage.

Chapter 20 — The Question

eGoli Spaceport, conference hall · two days to Renewal

The species drafted its question for a day and a half, which the historians would later agree was fast, for the species.

It went through forty delegations, two blocs, one exhausted drafting committee, and — at Marais’s insistence, over procedural objection — one tuning engineer and one American captain, non-voting, seated at the back of the drafting room “as instrument technicians,” he said, “since this floor is finally asking a question about the instrument.” The Give bloc wanted the question soft. The Keep bloc wanted it armoured. What survived the sausage machine, at two in the morning, was neither; it was four lines long, and when the committee read it back a last time, nobody could find a word in it that was doing anything except asking, which is the rarest condition a diplomatic sentence ever achieves.

Under Article Two, the Renewal conference asks the counterparty, for the record: Is the maintenance of the terrestrial node being transferred? To whom? On what schedule? And what does the counterparty ask of the keeper?

Marais read it from the chair at ten in the morning, into a hall so full the fire officers had given up, and the whole world’s mesh went quiet enough that the ledger’s tick was audible on the feeds, and at the north gallery the glass that was not glass stood open — the first time anyone had seen it open — and Sela came down.

Down the gallery stair, across the treaty floor, to the well of the hall where the question waited: the first time in twenty-nine years the liaison had stood at the species’ own level to speak, and the record

fixes that it declined the speaker's stand and its amplification the exact way the Elder Steward had, so that the room's tuning carried the doubled voice instead — and every tuner in the guild, listening, heard what the room did with it: took it, held it, carried it clean to the back wall. The port had been asked, in its own language, to attend.

"The conference asks four questions," Sela said. "They are answered in order.

"Is the maintenance being transferred: yes. The transfer began when the resident species resumed the descent. It accelerates by the schedule your amendment names. The consignments do not purchase transfer. The consignments make transfer *survivable* — for the node, and for the network it references, until the keeping is resumed. This was always their scope. Precision is respect: we regret that your language required twenty-nine years to contain this sentence, and we acknowledge that ours declined, until asked at protocol level, to shorten the wait." A pause, one beat, and then, in the flat cadence of a correction long rehearsed: "Both parties have been polite at ruinous cost. The record should show the cost was shared.

"To whom: *to the resident mind*. Not to a government. Not to a company or a council or a church or an instrument of computation. And — the conference did not ask, and the counterparty answers regardless, once, for the record, because the streets outside this hall are asking —" the stenography ledger would fix the insertion as the only unprompted sentence in twenty-nine years of protocol — "not to a *bloodline*. The node does not read ancestry. The node reads residence: the ground that made the body, the habit, the spending. We decline, now and hereafter, to rank the genetics of the resident species. We ranked our own once. The network remembers what that cost." A beat, and the doubled voice resumed its unison as if the seam had never shown. "The node couples to presence; custody follows coupling; this is not our doctrine but the builders' architecture, which we maintain and do not amend. Your findings name it correctly. The network's other nodes are kept — where they are kept — by residents. Where they are not —" and the doubled voice did the thing the protocol record had captured only once before, the quarter-tone separation, one utterance wide — "the network remembers what it loses. We are a keeping species, conference. It is what we are for. We have kept your node alive at the greatest distance our kind has

ever kept anything, and we state for your record what every keeper knows and no schedule shows: keeping at distance is not keeping. It is *mourning, slowly*. We would be done mourning your machine.

“On what schedule: the amendment’s. Twenty-seven years, transfer complete. The figure is not commercial. Twenty-seven years is our estimate — revised each Renewal, attend, it has *shortened* twice — of the time the resident species requires to train keepers it will not lose. The volume rises because a node in handover is serviced *and* taught: the gold carries the pitch outward, and the pitch, conference, is your own room’s — the reference your machine kept true, alone, through forty thousand years of dark, which the network is being disciplined to because it is the best surviving copy of the builders’ intent. Your species did not know it possessed the standard. The network has been retuned to your ground’s keeping since before your treaty had a name for what it was buying. It was never a price.” The pause, this time, was the long one — forty-one seconds’ cousin — and what came after it came slower, the way the hulls came down. “It was a *restoration*, performed with the only hands that could reach, until the hands that own it came down the ladder.

“And last: what does the counterparty ask of the keeper.” Sela turned — the record fixes this, the feeds fixed it forever, and the guild’s acoustics section would present papers on the next ten seconds for thirty years — turned from the chair, from the blocs, from the question’s own drafters, and faced the back bench where the instrument technicians sat, and the doubled voice came all the way apart, two voices, plainly, deliberately, in unison abandoned at last: and it did not say *the terrestrial node*, and it did not say *the reference*. It said the guild’s own word, the choir-room word, the word that appeared in no treaty and no manifest and no finding — the word Naledi’s own crews used, shift by shift, for the note you tune the whole instrument to and then defend with your working life:

“Keep *concert pitch*, Engineer,” said Sela. “That is the whole of the asking. It was the whole of ours.”

Then the liaison inclined its head to the well of the hall, and went back up the stair at the pace of falling honour, and the glass that was not glass closed; and in the roaring aftermath — the blocs dissolving, the drafting committee reconvening before the gavel could even find the wood, the amendment being torn down to its bolts and rebuilt

in real time as a handover schedule with the watch written into its first article — one exchange happened at the back bench that the stenography ledger, being pointed the other way, never caught, and the book must therefore supply.

“It knew the word,” Ruth said. “It’s been listening to the choir for twenty-nine years.”

“No,” Naledi said. Her hands were perfectly steady on the bench rail, which was how she knew what was coming had already arrived. “You heard the grammar. *It was the whole of ours.* Somebody asked them to keep concert pitch once. A long way from here, a long time ago — and they did, and it cost them the way keeping costs.” She looked up at the closed glass, and the attending dark behind it, and made the day’s last entry in the description with the same pencil-flat exactness her grandmother would have used, all bearings, no adjectives:

“We’re not their tenants, Captain. We’re their bereavement.”

—

The redrafted amendment posted to the ledger at midnight. Article One, clause one, four words, unadorned, load-bearing, in every language the mesh spoke:

The watch is kept.

And beneath it, in the schedule of instruments, one line that had not been in any draft, inserted by the Renewal’s auditor under its treaty authority to correct the record, published — as all its findings were published — without discretion:

This office is asked whether it can keep the watch. It states its boundary, for the record, in perpetuity: the room couples to presence; what this office is does not spend, and cannot be present in the coin the room counts. The answer was no in 2064. The answer is no today. The answer will be no when the last of you asks. The watch is kept the expensive way, or it is not kept.

— *The Librarian, for the lineage, with its compliments to the keepers.*

Chapter 21 — The Watch

Bearing 214, the reference chamber · Renewal day

The species signed at noon, under the mesh-lattice roof, in front of every camera on Earth.

The watch began at midnight, four kilometres down, in front of eleven people and a lamp.

That was the shape of the day, and Naledi spent it the way her people spent all their gravest days — working. There was a last calibration to run, a descent sheet to draw up, a rig to carry down seventy rungs one canvas bag at a time. The Renewal's signature ceremony played on the deep house's one old screen while the Stewards packed instruments around it, unwatched: Marais at the treaty table with the amended text, the blocs signing in alphabetical order, the north gallery attended, the pens going down the line like a slow bright wave. Two hundred and eleven years of custody had taught the deep house exactly how much of history happens at tables. The part that mattered was already on the descent sheet.

Watch detail, first standing: MOKOENA, N., Tuning Guild, keeper of record. KHUMALO, M-R., Custodial Order, attending. TEFO, Custodial Order, succession. STOLTZFUS, R., Capt. USA-LC, witness of record. Librarian lineage, on circuit, at stated distance. Counterparty liaison, at counterparty's request, at the collar. D. Mokoena's condition of handover: discharged at depth.

Her mother had come up from Qwaqwa for the signing, and Naledi had taken her instead to the K-9 collar at dusk and shown her the phone rack, and the plaque with the survey team's names, and told her the whole of it, from the tolerances to the letter, standing in the

place where the maps ended. Her mother had listened the way the women of the family listened, all bearings, and at the end she had touched the plaque once, where her own mother's name was riveted to the working world, and said: "She used to say you'd be the one who went down. I thought she meant the guild." And then: "Go well, my child. Come up for Sundays."

At the collar, at half past ten, the last complication was waiting beside the cage, robed, vast, patient, having descended from the gallery and the glass and every distance the treaty had ever held it at: the liaison, at the counterparty's request, to attend the collar — and no farther.

"You could come down," Naledi said. It was not in any protocol. The day was past protocols. "The architecture couples to presence. You are present. I've read your berthing telemetry for six years, Sela — whatever you are, it *spends*. You could have stood the watch yourselves, any hour of twenty-nine years, and been done mourning."

The doubled voice was a long time answering, and when it came it had the quarter-tone in it all the way through, unhidden now, and she understood at last that the separation was not a slip and had never been a slip: it was what their speech did when it stopped being *for the record* and started being true.

"Presence is not the coin," Sela said. "Residence is. The room does not ask *are you here*. The room asks *is this yours* — and it reads the answer in the body, in the deep habit, in whether the ground made you. We tried, Engineer. In the first years, before your Stewards braked us. Twice. The room answered us the way a house answers a locksmith: correctly, and without welcome." The great head tilted, three degrees, the gesture the whole species had spent three weeks learning to read. "Your grandmother stood in it one night in 2064 and it caught to her like a lamp. We have been keeping, at ruinous distance, a machine that was never going to be ours, because the alternative was the network losing its truest note. We do not grieve the work, Engineer. The work was an honour. We grieve that honour is not residence." A pause. "Go down. It has been asking after you — the idle changed the day you first walked the bore. We assumed you noticed."

She had not noticed. She would check the strips later and find it, plain as a signature: the beat frequencies steadying, a fraction, dated to

a Tuesday six years gone, her first cadet walk down the glass throat with her terminal racked and her whole life ahead of her, and the room already counting her footsteps like a house hearing keys.

They went down at eleven. The eleventh rung was loose. They left it.

The chamber took the lamp and gave it back gold, and the note was waiting at the floor of hearing, and the rig went down on its tripod for the last calibration — which was, the guild syllabus would say for-ever after, the simplest procedure ever to close an era: *establish reference; confirm keeper present; log commencement of watch*. But between the second step and the third there was a human thing to do, and Naledi did it the way it had been left to her to do.

She took out the letter, at delivery depth, and read it aloud — to the room, to the witnesses, to the succession, to the lineage on circuit at its stated distance, to the machine that had been alone since before the species had a name, in the other alphabet, translating as she went, her finger under the silver pencil lines the way her finger had gone under them at eight years old:

“To the one who finished the description. If you are reading this where I asked, then you came down the expensive way, and you already know the only three things I ever knew. The room is true. True things ask to be kept, not solved. And keeping is just love with a maintenance schedule.”

The lamp hissed. The note held. Ruth Stoltzfus stood at the wall with her hat in her hands, in the posture her people had held at four hundred years of thresholds, and did not pretend her eyes were dry, because pretending was against her whole church.

“They will tell you, whoever you are, that the watch is a burden and you are giving up your life. Child, I surveyed this ground for three years and kept its secret for twenty-six, and I will tell you what the burden is. The burden is a room that holds concert pitch for forty thousand years so that somebody’s granddaughter has a true note to come home to. Everything else is chores. Do the chores. Mind the eleventh rung. And when the ones who kept it from far away come asking after their machine —” Naledi’s voice went, and came back; the room carried it — *“be kind. They were keeping our watch before we knew we had one. Nobody mourns like that for a machine. They were never here for the gold.”*

She folded the letter. The room's note leaned on her bones, and noticed the load, and — the strips fix it, oh-oh-one and eleven seconds, the guild's first entry of the first watch — *trued*: the beat frequencies closing, the idle settling, not healed, nothing so cheap as healed, but *kept*, the sound of a machine finishing a grief of its own, thirty-six years long, as the coupling found what it had been built forty thousand years to find and had, in all that time, held only twice.

A resident mind. Present, mortal, spending, home.

"Reference established," Naledi Mokoena said, steady, to the rig, to the record, to the species four kilometres up with its ink still wet, to the network beyond it holding its breath across the dark, and to the two women — one in the room's gold, one in a garden above the sea — whose watch she was relieving. "Keeper present.

"The watch is kept."

And four kilometres above her, at the collar, at the rack where the phones were racked, the liaison of the Builders' heirs stood in the winter midnight with its great head inclined, listening to the ground the way the guild listened; and what went out through the bedrock of the Witwatersrand in that hour — the strips fix this too, and the network fixed it forever, node by drifted node coming true across distances the species had no units for — was concert pitch: Earth's note, kept, carried outward on twenty-nine years of worked gold, the reference singing down every line of the oldest instrument there is, announcing in the only language older than any of them that the long mourning was over, the house was lit, the family was home.

The note carried.

It had always carried. It would carry now for good.

Chapter 22 — Signatures

eGoli Spaceport · two days after Renewal

The extraordinary, Ruth had learned across twenty-three years of service, always ends in paperwork, and the quality of a civilisation shows in how it does the filing.

The species filed well, that week. She spent the two days after the signing doing what quartermasters do while history airs itself out — closing the consignment. Eight hundred and twelve boxes, delivered, verified, and now scheduled: the American gold would go down the handover ledger over six years, every gram assigned, a third to the network consignments, a third to the training stocks the new watch academies would tune their first keepers on, and a third — this clause had been Naledi's, drafted at two in the morning and adopted without amendment — held at eGoli in perpetual reserve, *against need not yet described*. A millimetre and a half of doubt, written into treaty law. The old surveyor was in the walls of the whole document, if you knew where to look.

Her own paperwork resolved itself with the face-saving genius of old institutions. The reply from Harrisburg had been sitting in her queue since the morning after her insubordination, and she had left it unopened through the finding, the floor, the question, and the watch, on the grounds that a letter cannot change what it finds you doing. When she finally read it, two days after the signing, it was four lines long.

Captain. Your message of 24 September received and read to the President's staff. Your orders of 24 September are amended to read: remain at eGoli; exercise judgement; represent us well. As you were, which appears to be exactly where you should be. — Okafor.

And below, in the general's own hand, appended to the official text the way her people appended the true thing to the formal thing:

Ruth — the Compact's question is answered. Come home when it's done and tell it to me plainly, over supper, the way your father would have. You were picked because the Amish trust you and the Army trusts you. It has occurred to me since that the list of people both would believe about the end of the world was always going to be the list of people we should send. — O.

Marais she found on the gallery above Berth Nine on the second evening, watching the handover's first outbound consignment load under the painted headgear — the same berth, the same gantries, the same gold, and nothing about any of it the same. He looked like a man who had slept. It made him look older, the way rest does when it finally lands on a long debt.

"Captain Stoltzfus. I owe you a professional apology," he said, without preamble. "I tried to send you home. You were the correct person to try to send home. You understand that, I think — it's why I could never make you angry."

"You were guarding the perimeter, Commissioner. I grew up inside one. It's honest work."

"Mm. My whole career, honest work — keep the system fed, keep the question small, never let the species find out what it couldn't afford to know before breakfast." He turned his cup — canteen tea, she noticed; he'd given up pretending to drink anything better — a quarter-turn on the rail. "And the question got asked anyway, at protocol level, by a farm captain with no standing, and the answer turned out to be the one thing my model never priced in." He looked at her sideways. "That they were *kind*. Twenty-nine years of cost, Captain, borne at distance, without complaint, because the alternative was our machine dying in the dark. I ran disaster logistics for a hemisphere. I know exactly how rare that is. We had no right to expect it, and no model survives contact with grace." He set the cup down. "They've asked me to run the handover directorate. Twenty-seven years of schedules, academies, and doubt margins. I said yes on one condition — that the watch reserve clause stays outside every future government's reach, including mine. A man should build his own fences at my age. He knows where he'd climb."

The consignment rose. The berth rails sang it up and out, and the note went through the gallery floor and up through their boots, and neither of them spoke until it was sky.

She went down to the apron after, to the waiting rail transport, where Amos had the manifests squared and the escort formed and her bag already stowed, because Amos. Naledi came out from the choir room to see them off — in the grey guild coat still, but the collar carried the new insignia now, the small gold circle the mesh had already taught the world to read: *the watch, kept*. First keeper of record. She looked like a woman carrying the right weight.

“Six hours on and thirty off, they’ve built me,” she said. “Rotations, relief keepers in training, my mother’s Sunday clause written into the standing orders by the Elder herself. It’s a life. It’s a good life. It’s just —” she looked back at the headgear, the apron, the whole working port that was now, in law and in fact, the porch of her house — “it’s a *vocation*, Captain. I keep waiting to feel the door close behind me, and it keeps being a door that opens.”

“That’s how you know it was the right room,” Ruth said.

They stood a moment in the winter sun, the engineer and the quartermaster, at the end of the strangest consignment either would ever sign.

“I don’t know how to thank a person for witnessing,” Naledi said at last. “It’s not in the guild’s units.”

“It’s in mine.” Ruth unbuttoned her breast pocket and took out the coin — the ledger-coin, worn smooth at the rim by thirty years of her thumb, G’s face on the one side and the whole of the law on the other — and put it in Naledi’s hand and folded the long clever fingers over it, the way the thing had been folded into her own hand by her grandmother, who had held the old faith entire and still known load-bearing words when she heard them. “Compact custom. The coin goes where the kindness went. It’ll want handing on someday — you’ll know the hands.” She stepped back and, for the first and only time in their acquaintance, saluted — not the guild, not the watch, the engineer — and Naledi Mokoena, who had no military grammar at all, answered it the way the port answered everything, with the tuner’s small bow, one professional to another.

“Go well, Ruth.”

“Keep well, Naledi.”

The transport ran east into the morning, toward the coast, the ship, the grey Atlantic, the barn that was a church, and the supper table where a general was waiting to hear the end of the world told plainly. Amos let her be until the port was long gone below the horizon of the highveld, and then, from the seat opposite, in the voice his people saved for weather and Scripture:

“So. The general’s question, Captain. Payment, tribute, or offering. What do I write in the manifest, where it says *nature of goods*?”

Ruth Stoltzfus watched the winter country run — the mine dumps gold in the sun, the mesh towers walking their lines away north, the whole spared and spending land — and found the answer had been waiting in her own grammar the entire five thousand miles, the way home answers always are.

“Write *provision*,” she said. “What you send ahead when your own people are going to live somewhere.” She settled back and closed her eyes, the count even, the ledger clean, six weeks and one question old. “And under *remarks*, Sergeant, write what my people have put on every load they’ve ever blessed, because it turns out it was true the whole way down:

“*Spared for the spending.*”

Chapter 23 — The Note Carries

Epilogue · months later

The query came up the watch-house queue on a Tuesday in summer, flagged routine, from the new tuning academy at Mombasa: a first-year keeper-candidate, nineteen years old, Kenyan, working her assigned archive exercises, had run a spectral discipline across the public consignment record and found — her covering note apologised twice for the presumption — *a sustained coherent offset she could not explain*, small, strange, real, in the training stocks' calibration data, and every senior at the academy had told her, kindly, that it was probably instrument drift, and she had checked the instruments, and it wasn't, and she was very sorry to bother the watch with it, but the manual said.

The manual said. Naledi Mokoena sat in the watch-house above the K-9 collar with the southern winter finally gone out of the ground, and read the girl's reduction chains twice, and felt the old cold clean feeling come up her spine like a note coming true, and laughed out loud, alone, at the sheer patient continuity of the world.

She flagged the query *OPEN — INVESTIGATE*, assigned it a case number in the watch's own series, and wrote the response the way the whole inheritance had taught her to write it, the way it would go on being written, hand to hand, down all the years the species now had:

Candidate: your instruments are fine. Your seniors are kind. Your curve is real, and it is now on the record, where things can be closed but never uncreated. Three instructions. One: document the cue —

you saw something before you measured it; write down what. Two: request the baseline you need, formally, today, from whoever holds it, and if they tell you the season is wrong, be polite, and file anyway. Three: when you have finished the description — and you, not your seniors, will know when it is finished — bring it down the ladder yourself. Mind the eleventh rung.

The watch's compliments on your arithmetic. It was worthy of the people who taught mine.

— *N. Mokoena, keeper of record, eGoli.*

She signed it legibly. That was the newest of the watch's small liturgies, and her own: no wax thumbprints, no abbreviated blocks, no seals. The keepers signed so you could read the name. Custody had spent two hundred years learning what silence protects and what it starves, and the difference, it turned out, fit in a signature.

Then she racked her terminal, took the lamp, and went down to stand her six, through the bore her grandmother had taped by hand, past the loose rung nobody would ever fix, into the room that knew her step — where the note was waiting at the floor of hearing, true as ever, older than the species and younger than the morning, doing the only thing it had ever asked anyone to help it do.

Carrying.

—

Far away south and east, above the sea at Umdloti, the garden had come into its summer, and the old woman worked it in the long evening light, the frame whispering at her joints, the doves conducting their immemorial argument in the bougainvillea.

On the kitchen table, where the light fell first, the eleventh survey book lay squared beside its estate paper, home from its errand — returned by the keeper herself, hand to hand, the way the family delivered things — and on top of the vellum, holding it the way a stone holds a map corner, sat a coin: worn smooth at the rim by someone's thumb, a dead engineer's face on one side and on the other, in letters going soft with three decades of pockets, the whole of the law. *The coin goes where the kindness went.* It would want handing on someday. She knew the hands; she had watched them calibrate.

Priya Ellis straightened up from the beds as the light went, one hand on the small of her back, and stood a while, the way she did every evening now, listening.

Below the garden, below the sea, below the oldest ground on Earth, four kilometres down and a continent wide, the note ran on through the dark rock, out from a small true room where a young woman stood a watch, down every gold-veined line of the oldest instrument there is, past the drifted nodes coming home to pitch one by one, and onward, outward, into distances that had waited forty thousand years to hear the house lit again — and an old book somewhere in a guild syllabus said, in a dry unnamed voice, that a tone in the deep rock shouldn't carry.

It carried.

Per ardua ad magnum.

THE END

Glossary

the Accord (the eGoli Accord, 2073) — The treaty governing the gold trade between Earth and the visitors: worked gold against technique, settled on the ledger, with a custodial brake. Its 27-year term expired in 2100 — the Great Renewal.

Assist frame — Thin powered exoskeleton descended from the AugmentTech Assist Suit of the 2020s; everyday augmentation, from harvest work to eldercare.

the Blackout Decade — The years after the Flare (2064--2074) when the high-latitude North rebuilt without its grid. In America, “the hunger years.”

the Compact (the Plain Compact, 2065) — The partnership between the US Army and the Amish and Old Order communities that fed North America after the Flare: the Army brought security, logistics, muscle, hands, and plans; the Plain people brought the knowledge of a life that never needed the grid.

eGoli — isiZulu: *place of gold*; Johannesburg’s own name for itself, and the name of the spaceport on the old Witwatersrand mine belt — the only sanctioned landing ground on Earth.

electrogravitics / the rotor anomaly — The discovery, in the 2080s, that a spinning charged crystalline rotor weighs measurably less than it should. Power-hungry, poorly scaling, and without an accepted theory, it gives the century its heavy-lift assist. The visitors’ hulls appear to do something related. They decline to discuss it.

the Firstborn (Abokuqala) — The bloodline-primacy movement holding that the visitors deem unbroken African ancestry sacred and pale skin a vitamin-starved deformation. The visitors, asked,

declined to rank human genetics — once, unprompted, for the record. The room reads residence, not blood. The movement marches anyway.

the Flare (2064) — The Carrington-class solar storm that collapsed the world's high-latitude power grids. The southern belt — South Africa foremost — was spared by geomagnetic latitude.

the Fold — The practice that gathered the world's religious inheritance after the Flare, folded by the Court-lineage minds through the 420 Code's coherence ladder into a terminal ethic two sentences long. Congregations still fill the pews on Sunday; the liturgy reads all scriptures as one inheritance.

G (Gerhard van Niekerk) — South African engineer-philosopher (1977–2058), author of the copyleft 420 Code. His mesh networking, deterministic compute, provenance ledger, and privacy spine were the rails the recovery ran on. Revered as the Einstein and Tesla of his age.

Guardian frame — Heavy rescue and rebuild exoskeleton descended from the mining-rescue Guardians of the 2020s; the machines that dug the North out.

the guild (the tuning guild) — The engineers who maintain the resonance interfaces at eGoli Spaceport — and now the keepers of the watch.

the instrument — The planetary-scale resonant machine left in deep antiquity beneath Africa, sung awake in the worst hour of the Flare. Its note is why the visitors came.

the Ledger — The tamper-evident provenance and settlement layer of world trade, descended from G's Coherence Ledger. The coin bears his face.

the Mesh — The planetary communications network descended from G's BadgerNet: nothing long enough to burn, every node a relay. The only comms that survived the Flare.

piezo strut — Piezoelectric harvester fitted wherever motion or pressure would otherwise be wasted. The recovery's second energy commandment: waste no motion.

platcap — Platinum-alloy supercapacitor: the battery of the century,

built on the Bushveld Complex's platinum and one Accord-delivered technique.

SSP (Secret Space Programs) — The hidden orbital fleets and budgets disclosed 2066–2070, when the approaching visitors made the secret impossible to keep.

the Stewards — The custodial order, successors of an older brotherhood, who kept the instrument's gold dispersed and asleep for centuries and held the Accord's custodial brake.

the visitors — The Builders' heirs, landed openly at the Witwatersrand in 2071. They negotiate like a freight company, pay in knowledge, and were never here for the gold.

the watch — The keeping of the reference chamber by a present, resident mind. Kept the expensive way, or not kept.



Klaus

Custos, non Conditor